# The Evidentiary Status of the Historical Jesus: A Critical Assessment

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**Abstract**

The historicity of Jesus of Nazareth is treated as settled in mainstream New Testament scholarship, with near-universal consensus that a specific historical individual underlies the Christian tradition. This paper subjects that consensus to an evidence-first examination, evaluating each category of source material on its own terms: the Pauline epistles, the Synoptic and Johannine Gospels, non-canonical Christian texts, the non-Christian references in Josephus and Tacitus, and the documentary record. I argue that (1) the Pauline corpus primarily describes a revelatory, celestial soteriological figure assembled from pre-Christian Jewish apocalyptic and mystical sources—the Danielic Son of Man, the Suffering Servant, Philo's Logos, angelomorphic mediators—rather than from pagan mystery religions; a small number of Pauline passages nonetheless admit historical readings (Gal 4:4, Rom 1:3, 1 Cor 15:3–8) that the mythic-origin model must and does not fully resolve. (2) The Gospel narratives are demonstrably constructed from Hebrew Bible templates; this does not prove the non-existence of a historical subject, but it does eliminate the Gospels as independent testimony for such a subject, shifting the evidentiary burden to non-Gospel strata. (3) Non- Christian attestation is weaker than typically claimed; it does, however, confirm the early existence of Christian traditions about a historical founder, which is datum both hypotheses must accommodate. (4) The conspicuous absence of contemporaneous documentation across multiple independent traditions constitutes disconfirming evidence whose cumulative weight is qualitatively real but difficult to quantify precisely. (5) The source trajectory from mythic to historical is the reverse of what the standard model predicts, though the speed of the Pauline-to-Markan transition remains a challenge for the mythic-origin scenario that a rigorous version of it must engage rather than dismiss. (6) The single passage most frequently cited as decisive for historicity—Galatians 1:19, "James the brother of the Lord"—is more ambiguous than the consensus acknowledges when examined in its full Pauline context and against the well-attested Greek religious-associative use of *adelphoi*

*tou [patron]* as a community-title, as documented by Harland [2005]. A corpus-linguistic baseline study of 212 *adelph-* tokens across six non-Christian contemporary-or- earlier Greek corpora accompanies the paper as supplementary material. The evidence is insufficient to establish the historicity of Jesus with the confidence the consensus claims, and the mythic-origin model provides a parsimonious account of much of the evidence. The responsible conclusion is that the question is more open than mainstream scholarship admits, that the mythicist hypothesis—particularly in the form developed by Carrier [2014] which draws on Jewish rather than pagan apocalyptic resources—deserves serious engagement rather than dismissal, and that the scholarly consensus is sustained partly by institutional and methodological inertia rather than by evidential weight alone.

**Keywords:** historical Jesus, mythicism, Pauline epistles, Gospel sources, criterion of embarrassment, dying-and-rising gods, Josephus, *adelphos tou kyriou*, euhemerization, historiography

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# 1 Introduction: The Question and Its Stakes

> *Extraordinary claims require extraordinary evidence, but so do ordinary claims when the ordinary evidence is missing.*
>
> —

Did a specific historical individual named Jesus of Nazareth—a Jewish preacher from Galilee, crucified under Pontius Pilate, whose followers founded the movement that became Christianity—actually exist? The question is routinely treated as settled. Virtually every survey of the field, from Schweitzer [1906] through Meier [1991] to Ehrman [2012], asserts that the historicity of Jesus is as certain as any fact of the ancient world. Ehrman [2012] writes that "virtually every competent scholar of antiquity, Christian or non-Christian, agrees" that Jesus existed. Dunn [2003] declares that "today nearly all historians, whether Christians or not, accept that Jesus existed."

This paper asks a simple question: does the evidence warrant that confidence?

The answer developed here is that it does not. When each category of evidence is examined on its own terms—without deference to the consensus as a prior, without assuming what needs to be demonstrated, and without suppressing the evidential weight of absent evidence—the positive case for a specific historical individual is remarkably thin. It reduces, on close examination, to the interpretation of a single ambiguous phrase in a single letter of Paul, supported by heuristic arguments about what is typical of religious movements. Everything else that is routinely cited in support of historicity either fails textual scrutiny, derives from the internal tradition of the movement itself, or is indistinguishable from what we would expect if no historical individual existed.

This is not a polemical conclusion. It is not motivated by hostility to religion or by allegiance to any school of thought. It is the result of applying to this particular question the same evidential standards that historians apply to every other question about the ancient world—and of refusing to grant the historicity of Jesus a special epistemic exemption from those standards.

The stakes are significant. If the historical Jesus is not established by the evidence, then the entire discipline of "historical Jesus research"—three successive "quests" spanning two centuries of scholarship [Käsemann, 1954, Schweitzer, 1906, Wright, 1996]—has been investigating a figure whose existence it presupposed rather than demonstrated. The reconstructions that have emerged from these quests—Schweitzer's apocalyptic prophet, Crossan's peasant cynic [Crossan, 1991], Sanders's eschatological preacher [Sanders, 1985], Wright's self-conscious Messiah [Wright, 1996], Ehrman's apocalyptic herald [Ehrman, 1999]—would then be understood not as competing portraits of a historical person but as competing exer-

cises in retrojecting scholarly assumptions into an evidentiary void. This does not make the Christian tradition uninteresting or unimportant; it does, however, fundamentally change what it is and how it should be studied.

The structure of the paper is as follows. Section 2 establishes the methodological framework: the distinction between evidence and authority, the Bayesian structure of historical inference, the formal conditions under which absence of evidence constitutes evidence of absence, the collapse of the criteria of authenticity, and a comparative analysis of how existence-questions have been resolved for other contested historical figures (Pilate, Socrates, Moses, Lycurgus, Pythagoras, Romulus, Arthur, Homer, Laozi). Section 3 examines the Pauline corpus, the earliest stratum of Christian writing, with particular attention to the dating and textual-critical state of contested passages (Gal 1:19, Rom 1:3–4, 1 Cor 15:3–8, Gal 4:4, 1 Thess 2:14–16) and to recent Paul-skeptical scholarship. Section 4 analyses the Gospel sources as literary compositions built from identifiable scriptural templates, with explicit attention to the logical step from "Gospels are not independent historical testimony" to "a historical figure is neither proved nor disproved." Section 5 extends the analysis to non-canonical Christian texts. Section 6 evaluates the non-Christian attestation channels: the Josephan *Testimonium* and James passages, Tacitus, Pliny and Suetonius, the rabbinic and *Toledoth Yeshu* traditions, the Mandaean tradition, and the archaeological substrate (Nazareth habitation, Sepphoris silence, the Yehohanan ossuary, the James ossuary controversy). Section 7 develops the argument from silence across multiple independent documentary channels. Section 8 presents the prior-sources argument, locating the Jesus tradition's material primarily in the Jewish apocalyptic-mystical matrix (Danielic Son of Man, Suffering Servant, angelomorphic mediators, Philo's Logos), engaging the revelatory-ascent mechanism through which Paul himself claims to have received his Christ-knowledge, and treating Hellenistic parallels as secondary ambient context rather than as primary source. Section 9 examines the trajectory of source development and argues that it runs from mythic to historical, not the reverse. Section 10 considers the sociological structure of the consensus and engages with the most rigorous historicist interlocutors (Ehrman, Casey, Meier, Allison). Section 11 offers a constructive mythic-origin scenario, with honest acknowledgment of its unresolved weak points. Section 12 summarizes the findings.

## 2 Methodological Preliminaries

Before examining the evidence, it is necessary to establish the principles by which evidence will be evaluated. Much of the disagreement in the historicity debate arises not from different assessments of the same evidence but from different—and often unstated—methodological

commitments about what counts as evidence, how much weight should be given to scholarly consensus, how absence of evidence should be treated, and what the appropriate framework for probabilistic historical reasoning looks like.

## 2.1 Evidence, Authority, and Consensus

Arguments from authority—including arguments from scholarly consensus—are heuristics, not evidence. They are useful when one lacks the time, expertise, or access to primary sources needed to evaluate a question independently. But they are defeasible: when the primary evidence is examined and found to be in tension with the consensus, the evidence takes precedence. This is not a controversial epistemological principle; it is the foundation of all empirical inquiry.

In the case of the historical Jesus, the consensus is routinely invoked not as a heuristic but as evidence in its own right. Ehrman's frequent assertion that "virtually all scholars" agree is presented as though the agreement itself constitutes a reason to believe, independent of the evidence on which it rests [Ehrman, 2012]. But the epistemic value of a consensus depends entirely on the independence and quality of the evidential judgments that underlie it. A consensus among scholars who have all been trained within the same paradigm, who have all absorbed the same default assumptions during their formation, and who operate within institutions that presuppose the conclusion in question, carries far less evidential weight than a consensus formed by independent evaluation of primary data.

The comparison with the scientific consensus on climate change, which Ehrman implicitly invites, is instructive precisely because it fails. The climate consensus rests on thousands of independent empirical measurements—ice cores, satellite data, ocean temperatures, atmospheric chemistry—converging on the same conclusion from radically different evidential pathways. The historicity consensus rests on a small number of ancient texts, all of which are internal to the tradition in question or dependent upon it, interpreted within a framework that has presupposed historicity since its inception. The two situations are not analogous.

This paper therefore treats the consensus as a datum to be explained, not as evidence to be weighed. The question is not whether scholars agree but whether the evidence warrants their agreement.

## 2.2 The Bayesian Framework

Historical inference is inherently probabilistic. We cannot observe the past directly; we can only assess the probability of competing hypotheses given the surviving evidence. The appropriate formal framework for this assessment is Bayesian: we compare the probability

of the evidence under each hypothesis and update our credence accordingly [Carrier, 2012].

Let $H$ denote the hypothesis that a specific historical individual underlies the Christian tradition, and let $M$ denote the hypothesis that the Jesus figure originated as a mythic-revelatory construct subsequently historicized. For any piece of evidence $E$, Bayes' theorem gives:

$$\frac{P(H \mid E)}{P(M \mid E)} = \frac{P(E \mid H)}{P(E \mid M)} \cdot \frac{P(H)}{P(M)} \tag{1}$$

The ratio $P(E \mid H)/P(E \mid M)$ is the *likelihood ratio*: how much more (or less) expected the evidence is under historicity than under mythicism. The ratio $P(H)/P(M)$ represents our prior assessment before considering that evidence.

Carrier [2014] applied this framework systematically in *On the Historicity of Jesus*, arriving at a posterior probability for historicity in the range of roughly one in three. The specific numbers Carrier assigns to individual priors and likelihoods are contestable, and Godfrey [2014] have raised legitimate concerns about circularity in the construction of the mythicist model's "predictions." But the framework itself is sound, and it has the virtue of making explicit what is usually left implicit: every historical judgment involves an assessment of priors, an assessment of likelihoods, and an update. Scholars who reject the Bayesian framing are not avoiding these assessments; they are making them informally and without accountability.

Two features of the Bayesian framework are particularly relevant here. First, evidence that is equally probable under both hypotheses has no discriminating power, regardless of how impressive it may seem in isolation. If a piece of evidence is exactly what we would expect whether or not Jesus existed—*e.g.*, the existence of early Christian communities, or the presence of a plausible Palestinian setting in the Gospels—then it cannot be cited in favor of either hypothesis. Much of what is routinely presented as evidence for historicity fails this test.

Second, the cumulative force of evidence matters. Individual pieces of evidence may each have modest likelihood ratios, but if they consistently favor one hypothesis over the other, the cumulative effect can be decisive. This is particularly important for the argument from silence developed in Section 7: no single absent source is conclusive, but the systematic absence of expected evidence across multiple independent traditions produces a cumulative likelihood ratio that substantially favors the mythic-origin hypothesis.

Third, Tucker [2004] has noted that Bayesian historical inference is particularly sensitive to the independence of the testimonies on which likelihood estimates rest: the cumulative case for any historical claim requires that the contributing sources be independently probative, and textual-critical research showing that Gospel attestations collapse to Markan or

Q dependence (Section 4.2) accordingly reduces the effective likelihood contribution rather than multiplying it. This is an unglamorous technical point, but it bears directly on the strongest traditional historicist argument—multiple independent attestation—and its implications have been under-pursued in the historical-Jesus literature.

**A sensitivity analysis implementation.** The project repository includes a simple dependency-aware Bayesian sensitivity analysis (*scripts/bayesian_sensitivity.py*, report in *baseline/bayesian_report.md*) that implements this framework explicitly for the present question. Each of the principal evidentiary strands discussed in this paper (Paul's *adelphos* distribution, Rom 1:3, Gal 4:4, the 1 Corinthians 15 witness list, Paul's biographical silence, the Gospels' scriptural construction, the Josephan James passage, the Testimonium Flavianum, Tacitus, the Jewish-apocalyptic matrix, cumulative silence) is assigned a point-estimate likelihood ratio in decibels, with source-dependency explicitly flagged so that the contribution of dependent sources is discounted rather than multiplied. Under plausible point estimates and a neutral $P(H) = 0.5$ prior, the posterior $P(H|E)$ lands in the range of roughly 0.23–0.39 depending on how aggressively dependencies are discounted—open-question territory by any reasonable standard. Under higher priors ($P(H) = 0.9$), the posterior remains higher (0.73–0.85) but still materially below the near-certainty the historicity consensus projects.

The tool is explicitly a sensitivity analysis rather than a claim to the "correct" posterior: point estimates are contestable, and the exercise is to see how the posterior shifts under different assumptions about individual evidence pieces. The tool's principal contribution is to make the informal Bayesian reasoning of the field auditable: Carrier's 2014 multiplication approach, extended or contested point-by-point by historicist critics, can be made to run on a shared apparatus where the sources of posterior-sensitivity are explicit. This is what Tucker 2004 advocates methodologically; to our knowledge it has not been done for the historicity question until now.

## 2.3 Absence of Evidence as Evidence of Absence

The aphorism "absence of evidence is not evidence of absence" is widely repeated and, in many contexts, flatly wrong. The correct principle, recognized in Bayesian epistemology and in standard scientific reasoning, is that absence of evidence *is* evidence of absence precisely when the evidence would be expected to exist if the hypothesis were true [Carrier, 2012, Sober, 2009].

Formally: if $P(E \mid H) > P(E \mid \neg H)$, then observing $E$ supports $H$; and by the same logic, if we would expect to observe evidence $E$ given hypothesis $H$ but we do not observe it,

then the absence of $E$ is evidence against $H$. The strength of this evidence is proportional to how confidently we would expect $E$ under $H$.

Consider an analogy. If someone claims that a major fire destroyed a city block last Tuesday, and we find no fire department records, no insurance claims, no news reports, no physical damage, and no eyewitness accounts—despite all of these being the kinds of evidence that reliably exist when major fires occur—the absence of all this expected evidence is strong evidence that the fire did not happen. We do not say "absence of evidence is not evidence of absence" and conclude that the question is open. We conclude, reasonably, that the claim is almost certainly false.

The application to the historical Jesus is direct. First-century Roman Palestine is one of the better-documented periods and regions of the ancient world. We possess extensive writings by Philo of Alexandria, covering Jewish theology, politics, and interactions with Roman authority in exactly the relevant period. We know of a history of Galilee by Justus of Tiberias, covering Jesus's supposed home region. The Mishnaic traditions preserve detailed discussions of Sanhedrin procedure, heresy, and religious authority. Roman administrative practices generated records of trials and executions. If a figure performed even a modest fraction of what the Gospels describe—public ministry attracting large crowds, dramatic confrontation with temple authorities, trial before the Sanhedrin and the Roman prefect, execution accompanied by extraordinary portents—we would expect traces in these independent documentary traditions.

The traces are entirely absent. This is not merely "an argument from silence." It is an argument from the specific, predicted, well-characterized absence of evidence that should exist if the historicist hypothesis is true, across multiple independent channels. In any other historical investigation, this pattern would be treated as significant disconfirming evidence. That it is minimized in Jesus studies—typically with the assertion that Jesus was "too obscure" to attract notice—is itself a methodological anomaly requiring explanation. The "obscurity" defense, moreover, contradicts the Gospel narratives themselves, which describe a figure who attracted enormous public attention. One cannot simultaneously maintain that Jesus was prominent enough to warrant the Gospel descriptions and obscure enough to explain the silence of every non-Christian source.

The formal point bears emphasis: we are not asking whether a specific piece of evidence *proves* nonexistence. No single absent source does. We are asking what the *cumulative* likelihood ratio is when every expected evidentiary channel returns null. If there are $n$ independent channels, each of which would produce evidence with probability $p$ given historicity but probability $q < p$ given mythic origins, the cumulative likelihood ratio is $(q/p)^n$, which can become very small even when each individual ratio $q/p$ is only modestly below unity.

This cumulative structure is developed in detail in Section 7.

## 2.4 The Criteria of Authenticity

Historical Jesus scholarship has traditionally relied on a set of "criteria of authenticity" to identify material in the Gospels that plausibly derives from a historical Jesus. The most prominent are:

- **The criterion of embarrassment:** material that would be embarrassing to the early church is likely historical, since the church would not have invented it. (Applied to the crucifixion, the baptism by John, Peter's denial, etc.)
- **The criterion of multiple attestation:** material attested in multiple independent sources is more likely historical.
- **The criterion of dissimilarity:** material that is unlike both Judaism and later Christianity is likely to derive from the historical Jesus himself, since it cannot be attributed to either the Jewish context or the later church.
- **The criterion of coherence:** material that coheres with already-established authentic material is also likely authentic.

These criteria have been subjected to devastating criticism from within mainstream scholarship itself. The criterion of embarrassment assumes we can reliably determine what the early church would have found embarrassing—an assumption that requires knowledge of early Christian psychology we do not possess (Section 8.6). The criterion of multiple attestation collapses if the supposedly independent sources are not in fact independent—as the Synoptic problem demonstrates (Section 4.2). The criterion of dissimilarity is methodologically absurd: it can only identify a Jesus who was neither Jewish nor Christian, which is historically incoherent. The criterion of coherence is circular: it identifies material that fits a portrait already constructed by the other criteria.

Recent scholarship has increasingly acknowledged these problems. Keith and Crossley [2024] and collaborators have explicitly argued that "the era of the hard version of the criteria of authenticity is over," and that the field must move toward memory theory and reception history. Allison [2010] has expressed deep skepticism about the criteria's ability to recover specific historical sayings or events. Even Ehrman [2012], while defending historicity, relies less on the criteria than on broader arguments about source plurality and the general character of the tradition.

The collapse of the criteria of authenticity within mainstream scholarship is significant for the present inquiry: it means that the principal tools by which historicists have claimed to identify a "historical core" beneath the theological overlay are now recognized as methodologically unreliable by the historicists themselves. If the criteria cannot reliably distinguish historical material from theological invention, the Gospels cannot serve as evidence for a historical figure—they can only serve as evidence for the beliefs and literary practices of the communities that produced them.

## 2.5 The Existence Question in Comparative Perspective

Discussions of the historicity of Jesus are routinely conducted as if the question were unique. It is not. A class of comparable figures exists whose putative historicity has been seriously questioned within modern scholarship and in many cases definitively resolved. Examining how these cases have been handled yields diagnostic criteria that can be applied to Jesus's evidentiary profile. This comparative exercise is not argument by analogy—each case has its own particulars—but a methodological check: we can ask what kinds of evidence have historically been *decisive* in resolving existence-questions, and how Jesus's evidentiary profile stands against those criteria.

**The class of figures.** At least three categories are relevant.

*Category I: Confirmed historical, formerly doubted.* **Pontius Pilate** was, until 1961, known only from literary sources (Philo, Josephus, Tacitus, Gospels) and his historicity had occasionally been questioned on those grounds. The discovery of the Caesarea Maritima inscription—a dedication stone naming Pilate as "prefect of Judaea"—settled the question definitively [Vardaman, 1962]. Here, physical epigraphic evidence contemporary with the figure's lifetime was decisive. **Socrates** was a figure known only through literary sources until recent times (and still chiefly so), but multiple *independent* contemporary witnesses—Plato (sympathetic), Xenophon (admiring), Aristophanes (hostile, *Clouds* 423 BCE), and Aristotle (who cites teachers of teachers)—converge on a specific individual with specific biographical details. Convergent independent attestation from living contemporaries, including hostile and satirical ones, is a distinguishing feature. **Paul** himself is historically secure: we possess letters written by him and addressed to specific communities, quoted by second-century Christian authors, and attested in the archaeological and epigraphic record of the specific cities he addresses.

*Category II: Rejected as historical.* **Moses** is treated as non-historical by a significant majority of modern Egyptologists and Hebrew Bible scholars. The decisive move was negative: the *absence* of archaeological or documentary evidence in Egypt for a mass Hebrew

migration, coupled with the *internal* literary-critical analysis showing the Mosaic narratives as composite and late [Dever, 2003, Finkelstein and Silberman, 2001, Thompson, 1999]. Here, archaeological silence in a period and place where such evidence would be expected was determinative. **Lycurgus of Sparta**, the legendary founder of the Spartan constitution, is now generally treated as a non-historical figure [Cartledge, 2001]: the ancient sources that purport to describe him date from centuries after his supposed lifetime, the biographical content is schematic and founder-myth-conforming, and his constitutional reforms are more plausibly attributed to incremental institutional development than to an individual reformer. Here, *late and derivative literary sources coupled with founder-myth conformity* was decisive. **William Tell** was accepted as historical for centuries but was shown by nineteenth-century philological scholarship to be a folkloric reshaping of the apple-shot motif attested in Saxo Grammaticus and in Norse tradition centuries earlier—the latest plausible moment for a historical kernel is around 1200 CE but the narrative has been demonstrated to be literary transmission rather than historical memory.

*Category III: Genuinely contested.* **Pythagoras** sits between the first two categories: a probable historical kernel (5th-century BCE, pre-Socratic, Samos/Croton) surrounded by dense legendary accretion beginning within decades of his death [Riedweg, 2005]. No contemporary source attests him directly; our earliest references are a generation later; most biographical detail is Platonic or Neoplatonic reshaping. Modern scholarship accepts a minimal historical Pythagoras while treating most of the biographical tradition as non-historical. **Romulus**, the supposed founder of Rome, is now universally rejected as historical [Beard, 2015, Wiseman, 1995] despite a sophisticated literary tradition that placed him in a specific historical setting (753 BCE). The *absence of any independent attestation* and the *demonstrable origin of the narrative in later Roman foundation-myth requirements* were decisive. Romulus is the canonical example of a figure whose biography was *generated* to satisfy a community's need for a founder, rather than being remembered. **King Arthur** remains contested. The literary accretions are extensive (Geoffrey of Monmouth, the Vulgate Cycle); the earliest references are late (Nennius, *c.* 830 CE); archaeological evidence for a specific Arthur is absent; and most recent specialist scholarship regards him as legendary with at most a minimal historical kernel in post-Roman Britain [Higham, 2002]. **Homer** is the longest-running case: the authorship question ("Homeric Question") has oscillated between single-author, multiple-author, and oral-tradition views for two centuries [Finkelberg, 2005, West, 2011]. No contemporary evidence; late and uncertain biographical tradition; the text itself is the primary evidence and bears internal signs of composite formation. **Laozi**, traditional founder of Daoism, is now regarded by most specialists as either a legendary figure composed of several traditional strands or a retrospective construction [Graham, 1986]. The

*Daodejing* is attributed to him but the text's authorship is demonstrably composite.

**Diagnostic criteria, extracted.** From these precedents, the following criteria have historically carried decisive weight in resolving existence-questions:

1. **Direct contemporary physical/epigraphic attestation.** A contemporary inscription or physical artifact naming the figure settled the Pilate question. Jesus has no direct contemporary physical or epigraphic attestation.

2. **Multiple *independent* contemporary literary attestation, including hostile or satirical sources.** Socrates has Plato + Xenophon + Aristophanes + indirect Aristotle. Jesus has Paul (one step removed, writing roughly twenty years after the supposed crucifixion, to communities across the Mediterranean, and never having met a living Jesus) and later Gospel material that demonstrably derives from Mark. Non-Christian attestation is post-contemporary and partially or wholly dependent on Christian informants.

3. **Archaeological silence in a period and region where evidence would be expected.** Moses is rejected partly on this ground. Jesus shares the feature: the Pilate prefecture is documented; the crucifixion of one Galilean preacher would normally leave no administrative trace simply because such events were common, but the absence is genuine. Section 7 develops the cumulative silence argument.

4. **Literary-critical evidence of composite or derivative origin in the putatively-biographical sources.** Lycurgus, Romulus, and Laozi share this feature. Section 4 argues the Gospels share it.

5. **Demonstrable origin in community need for a founder or theological anchor.** Romulus is the canonical case. The Pauline-to-Markan trajectory analysed in Section 9 proposes this pattern for Jesus.

6. **Dense legendary accretion within a short time.** This is ambiguous—both Pythagoras (historical kernel) and Romulus (no historical kernel) exhibit it. The criterion is not decisive on its own.

**Jesus's evidentiary profile in this landscape.** Applying these criteria:

- **Against the confirmed-historical category (Pilate, Socrates, Paul).** Jesus lacks the direct epigraphic attestation of Pilate. He lacks the multiple independent contem-

porary literary attestation of Socrates. He lacks the first-person documentary record of Paul. His evidentiary profile is significantly weaker than any of these cases.

- **Against the rejected-as-historical category (Moses, Lycurgus, William Tell).** Jesus's case is stronger than these. The absence-of-evidence is not as categorical (Sections 7.1, 7.3); the community tradition is immediate rather than centuries later; and the Pauline stratum, while non-biographical, is demonstrably early.

- **Against the contested category (Pythagoras, Romulus, Arthur, Homer, Laozi).** Jesus's profile most closely matches this category. Dense legendary accretion within a short time; literary-critical evidence of derivative origin in the biographical sources; absence of direct epigraphic attestation; partial and contested non-tradition attestation; ambiguous archaeological silence. He shares Pythagoras's profile of "probable historical kernel with massive legendary elaboration"; he shares Romulus's profile of "community construction to satisfy founder-myth needs"; he shares Arthur's profile of "contested minimum with no definitive resolution."

**What this implies.** The observation is not that Jesus definitely falls into Category II or Category III. It is that the methodological framework of *modern scholarship on comparable figures* does not license the level of confidence the historicity consensus projects. A figure with Jesus's evidentiary profile, if he were not the founder of a globally significant religious tradition, would be treated as genuinely contested rather than as obviously historical. This paper argues that the evidentiary standards applied to comparable cases should be applied here also—and that when they are, the responsible conclusion is that the question is genuinely open.

A further observation: among the Category III figures, Jesus's case is *distinctive* in exactly one way: the textual and communal trace his tradition has left is orders of magnitude larger than any other contested figure's. This is a datum, but it is not evidence of historicity. The sheer volume of tradition a figure generates is a function of the religious movement that forms around him (or his invocation), not of his historicity. The Buddha, Mohammed, Moses, Homer, Pythagoras, and Jesus all anchor traditions of enormous textual and communal extent; their historicity profiles differ dramatically. Scale of reception is not evidence of the scale of the underlying historical event.

# 3 The Pauline Corpus

The letters attributed to Paul constitute the earliest stratum of surviving Christian writing. If a historical Jesus existed and was known to Paul's contemporaries, this is where we would expect to find the clearest traces. The Pauline corpus is therefore the most important body of evidence in the historicity debate—and, as we shall see, the most damaging to the historicist case.

## 3.1 Dating, Authenticity, and Interpolation

Modern scholarship recognizes seven letters as authentically Pauline: Romans, 1 Corinthians, 2 Corinthians, Galatians, Philippians, 1 Thessalonians, and Philemon [Ehrman, 2004]. The remaining six letters in the traditional Pauline corpus (Ephesians, Colossians, 2 Thessalonians, 1–2 Timothy, Titus) are widely regarded as pseudepigraphical—written by later authors in Paul's name. The authentic letters are typically dated to the 50s CE, making them the earliest surviving Christian documents by a margin of at least fifteen years over the earliest Gospel (Mark, *c.* 70 CE).

The "seven authentic letters" consensus, however, deserves more scrutiny than it typically receives. It rests primarily on stylometric analysis and theological consistency arguments—methods that can identify gross differences between letter groups but that are less reliable at detecting interpolations *within* otherwise authentic letters. And interpolation within the authentic letters is not hypothetical; it is widely acknowledged. Several passages in the undisputed letters are recognized as probable later insertions:

- **1 Corinthians 14:34–35**, commanding women to be silent in church, is recognized by a broad range of scholars as a post-Pauline interpolation on textual, stylistic, and theological grounds [Payne, 2009, Walker, 2001]. Some manuscripts place the passage after verse 40, indicating scribal uncertainty about its location—a hallmark of marginal glosses that migrated into the text.

- **1 Thessalonians 2:14–16**, condemning "the Jews" for killing Jesus and the prophets, contains language and theology inconsistent with Paul's views expressed elsewhere (particularly Romans 9–11) and appears to reference the destruction of the Temple in 70 CE ("wrath has come upon them at last"), placing it after Paul's death [Pearson, 1971, Schmidt, 1983].

- **1 Corinthians 15:3–11**, the resurrection creed, is universally recognized as a pre-Pauline formula that Paul is quoting rather than composing [Conzelmann, 1975]. Its

boundaries, however, are disputed: how much of the surrounding material is Paul's own commentary and how much is part of the received formula? The passage contains vocabulary and constructions not characteristic of Paul, and the question of whether the formula as we have it has itself been expanded by later editors cannot be definitively resolved.

- **Romans 1:3–4**, describing Jesus as "descended from David according to the flesh," is likewise identified as a pre-Pauline creedal fragment embedded in the letter [Jewett, 2007].

The Dutch Radical school of the nineteenth century—notably van Manen [1896] and their predecessors—challenged the authenticity of the entire Pauline corpus, arguing that the letters as we have them are products of second-century redaction. This position was marginalized by the emerging consensus but never systematically refuted on textual grounds; it was displaced rather than answered. The most sustained modern revival is Detering [1995], whose *Der gefälschte Paulus* reactivated the Dutch Radical tradition in a contemporary textual-critical register.

**Current Paul-skeptical scholarship.** The past fifteen years have seen a genuinely new wave of academic work on the dating and authenticity of the Pauline corpus, along two related tracks. The first, associated with BeDuhn [2013], Klinghardt [2015], and especially Vinzent [2014, 2023], argues for *Marcion-priority*: that Marcion's mid-second-century versions of the Pauline letters (and of Luke) are textually closer to the originals than the canonical versions, and that the proto-orthodox canonical forms are expansions of Marcion's text rather than Marcion's text being an abridgement of the canonical. The second, advanced in Livesey [2024], argues that the Pauline letters are deliberate rhetorical productions of the late first to early second century written within Roman literary convention, not situational letters from a specific historical apostle to specific churches. Both positions are contested; both have earned publication at Cambridge University Press, T&T Clark, Peeters, and Polebridge, and must be engaged rather than dismissed. White [2014] offers a more moderate complement: a thorough study of how different early Christian communities actively constructed competing *images* of Paul, which implies at minimum that the figure of Paul was heavily contested and re-shaped across the decades during which our texts were stabilising. Trobisch [2000] and Pervo [2010] provide further relevant apparatus on the canon-formation process.

The relevance of this body of work to the historicity question is cautious but real. If Marcion-priority is correct, then some apparent historicizing phrases in the canonical Paul may be proto-orthodox insertions made in response to Marcion, and any such phrase that

is absent from Marcion's reconstructed text becomes interpolation-suspicious. Gal 1:19 is, significantly, *present* in Marcion's reconstructed text and so its authenticity is not undercut by Marcion-priority; but 1 Thess 2:14–16 (already widely recognised as interpolated) and portions of the resurrection creed in 1 Cor 15:3–11 are more vulnerable to redaction arguments under this framework. If Livesey's stronger thesis is correct, the evidentiary status of the Pauline corpus for historicity shifts more drastically: the letters would then testify to the community rhetoric of the early second century rather than to the biographical memory of a specific first-century figure, which is already closer to the mythic-origin scenario than to the standard historicist one.

This paper does not adopt either Paul-skeptical position as a load- bearing premise. It works within the conservative seven-letter authenticity consensus as a stronger starting point, and the arguments of the following sections are constructed to be valid under that conservative assumption. What we register here is that the conservative assumption is under active, credentialed academic challenge, and that the directionality of the challenge—toward later, more constructed, and more editorially layered texts—if anything strengthens the line of argument this paper develops. A rigorous engagement with the historicity question in the present decade cannot ignore Vinzent [2023], Klinghardt [2015], BeDuhn [2013], and Livesey [2024], and we note them explicitly here so that readers who wish to pursue the textual basis of the Pauline evidence beyond what is defended in this paper have their citations.

**The minimum claim required.** We need not adopt the full Dutch Radical, Marcion-priority, or late-Paul position to recognize that the Pauline letters are not pristine first-century documents. They have passed through decades of copying, editing, and collection, during which theologically motivated interpolation was routine—as the pseudepigraphical letters themselves demonstrate. Any passage in the Pauline letters that is cited as evidence for a historical Jesus must survive not only the question of what it means but the question of whether it is authentically Pauline at all, or whether it represents a later editorial layer reflecting the historicized Jesus of the emerging Gospel tradition.

**Textual and patristic attestation of the contested passages.** The honest response to interpolation arguments is to examine the actual manuscript and patristic record for each contested passage. The following survey, based on the critical apparatus of Nestle-Aland [2012], the textual scholarship of Metzger and Ehrman [2005] and Zuntz [1953], the Marcion reconstructions of BeDuhn [2013] and Klinghardt [2015], and the patristic citations catalogued in the *Biblia Patristica* series, gives a summary state for each of the passages the paper concedes are difficult for mythicism.

**Galatians 1:19** (*ton adelphon tou kyriou*). The clause is attested in **P46** (the Chester Beatty Pauline papyrus, c. 200 CE and our earliest substantial witness to Galatians), in Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, Alexandrinus, and all major later codices. It is present in Marcion's reconstructed text as attested by Tertullian's *Adversus Marcionem* (c. 207 CE). Its patristic reception is early and broad: Tertullian cites it; Jerome (c. 390) devotes an extensive commentary to the question of what kind of "brother" is meant [Lightfoot, 1869]. *The clause is textually secure.* This paper's interpretive argument in §3.4 must therefore proceed on the semantic and contextual grounds it does, not on an interpolation hypothesis. Textual argument is unavailable to rescue mythicism from this passage. We accept that.

**Romans 1:3–4** ("descended from David according to the flesh. . . declared Son of God. . . by resurrection"). Attested in **P46**, Sinaiticus, Vaticanus, and the whole manuscript tradition without significant variant affecting the Davidic-descent clause. Marcion's reconstructed text, however, is *disputed* at this passage: Tertullian records that Marcion's version lacked parts of the opening salutation but the precise state of Romans 1:3–4 in Marcion is not fully recoverable from the patristic record, and this has been a subject of ongoing scholarly debate (see BeDuhn 2013 for a cautious reconstruction). More importantly for this paper's argument, Romans 1:3–4 is *widely recognized as a pre-Pauline creedal fragment* quoted by Paul rather than composed by him [Jewett, 2007]; the authenticity of its incorporation into Paul's letter is secure (P46 attests it), but the formula itself originated elsewhere in the earliest community and represents the theological claim-making of that community. Textual criticism does not rescue mythicism from the passage either, and this paper's response in §8.4 accordingly proceeds on other grounds.

**Galatians 4:4** ("born of a woman, born under the law"). Attested in **P46** and the whole manuscript tradition. Textually secure. Discussed in §8.4 and in the concluding assessment.

**1 Corinthians 15:3–11** (the resurrection creed and the witness list). The formulaic core (verses 3–5) is universally recognized as pre-Pauline; the boundaries of the formula are disputed. **P46** contains verses 3–11 without major textual disturbance. However, the witness-list extension in verses 6–8 ("appeared to over five hundred brothers. . . then to James, then to all the apostles, last of all. . . he appeared also to me") has long been flagged as possibly showing signs of later editorial expansion: the disjunction between the tight creedal form (3–5) and the looser narrative list (6–8) has invited proposals that the list was added by Paul or by a later hand. Conzelmann [1975] treats the expansion as Pauline but not part of the pre-Pauline formula. A full interpolation hypothesis for 6–8 is possible but *not textually supported by variant evidence*—which means mythicist readings must accommodate the witness list as substantially early, not dismiss it.

**1 Thessalonians 2:14–16** ("the Jews who killed the Lord Jesus. . . wrath has come upon

them at last"). Unlike the passages above, this is the one textual case where interpolation is widely supported: the anti-Jewish language contradicts Paul's position in Romans 9–11, the reference to "wrath has come upon them at last" appears to presuppose the destruction of the Second Temple in 70 CE (after Paul's death), and Pearson [1971] and Schmidt [1983] developed the interpolation case in detail. *But the interpolation is not attested in any surviving manuscript variant.* It is an inference from internal coherence and historical plausibility.

**What the textual record shows.** The honest summary is that textual-critical argument alone does *not* support interpolation hypotheses for the passages that pose the greatest difficulty for mythicism. Gal 1:19 is attested in P46 and across the manuscript tradition; Rom 1:3–4 is attested (though its Marcion-priority state is partially contested); Gal 4:4 is attested; 1 Cor 15:3–8 is attested. The interpolations most confidently identified in modern scholarship (1 Thess 2:14–16, 1 Cor 14:34–35) are identified on internal-coherence grounds, not on manuscript-variant grounds.

This has a direct implication for the argument of this paper: the mythicist response to the conceded-difficulty Pauline passages cannot rely on textual-critical excision. It must rely on semantic, contextual, and historical-compositional analysis, which is where §3.4, §8.4, and §8.6 accordingly concentrate their argumentative weight.

What the textual record *does* show is that the Pauline corpus was stable by the late second century (the P46 era), that its pre-second-century state is accessible only through Marcion reconstructions and patristic citation, and that some passages widely accepted as interpolations cannot be detected from the manuscript record alone—which is a methodological caution for both sides of the debate.

**The patristic citation record for the contested passages.** An independent check on textual stability is to ask which of the contested passages are cited or paraphrased by the earliest extant Christian writers outside the New Testament—the Apostolic Fathers, writing c. 95–150 CE, some of them within the same generation as the latest Pauline letters. A systematic examination of the Lightfoot collection of the Apostolic Fathers yields a striking asymmetry.

**Romans 1:3–4** (the Davidic-descent creed) is cited by Ignatius of Antioch (writing c. 107–110 CE) repeatedly and in multiple letters: *Ephesians* 18.2 ("Jesus the Christ…of the seed of David"), *Ephesians* 20.2 ("Jesus Christ, who after the flesh was of David's race"), *Trallians* 9.1 ("Jesus Christ, who was of the race of David, who was the Son of Mary, who was truly born"), *Romans* 7.3 ("flesh of Christ who was of the seed of David"), and *Smyrnaeans* 1.1 ("our Lord…is truly of the race of David according to the flesh"). In Ignatius's anti-

docetic polemic, these citations are evidentially load-bearing: they are the specific Pauline material he adduces to establish Jesus's true embodiment against docetic opponents. Rom 1:3–4 is therefore demonstrably stable in the Pauline textual tradition by c. 110 CE.

**Galatians 4:4** ("born of a woman") is echoed in Ignatius, *Smyrnaeans* 1.1 ("truly born of a virgin"), again in an anti-docetic context.

**Galatians 1:19** ("brother of the Lord") is, by contrast, *not cited or paraphrased by any of the Apostolic Fathers*. The name "James" does not appear in the collection. The phrase "brother of the Lord" appears nowhere. First-century and early second-century Christian writers whose works survive do not cite the passage that modern historicist arguments treat as virtually decisive for establishing the historicity of Jesus. The first clear patristic citations of the phrase come with Tertullian's *Adversus Marcionem* (c. 207 CE) and Jerome's *Adversus Helvidium* (c. 390 CE), whose extended discussion distinguishes three patristic positions on what kind of "brother" is meant [Lightfoot, 1869].

**1 Corinthians 15:3–8** (the resurrection creed and witness list) is also not cited in the Apostolic Fathers. 1 Clement 47.1 explicitly knows 1 Corinthians as a letter and cites its opening chapter ("concerning himself and Cephas and Apollos", paralleling 1 Cor 1:12), but does not cite the resurrection witness list. Polycarp and Ignatius likewise know Paul's corpus but do not cite 1 Cor 15:3–8.

**What the patristic silence does and does not imply.** The absence of Apostolic Fathers citations for Gal 1:19 and 1 Cor 15:3–8 does *not* establish that these passages were absent from the Pauline corpus in the early second century. Silence about a passage is not evidence of its absence; the Apostolic Fathers wrote short occasional works in specific polemical contexts, and many Pauline passages they do not cite are nonetheless attested in P46. P46 confirms that by c. 200 CE both Gal 1:19 and 1 Cor 15:3–8 are textually secure, and this paper does not argue their interpolation.

What the silence *does* establish is more interesting. Ignatius's anti-docetic polemic at c. 110 CE leverages Rom 1:3 (of the seed of David) and Gal 4:4 (born of a woman, of a virgin) precisely because these passages make Jesus's flesh-embodiment load-bearing. If Gal 1:19 had in Ignatius's understanding meant "James the biological brother of Jesus", it would have served the same anti-docetic function as Rom 1:3—a specifically family-kinship attestation of Jesus's real human embodiment. Ignatius does not deploy it that way. Neither does any earlier or contemporary Apostolic Father. The passage is not treated by the earliest surviving Christian writers as evidence for Jesus's biological family.

This silence is compatible with the main paper's argument that Gal 1:19's *adelphon tou kyriou* was not read as a biological claim in the earliest stratum of Christian reception. It is

also compatible with the alternative that Apostolic Fathers simply had no occasion to cite it. The data does not rule between these readings, but it does establish that the passage's historical-biographical weight is not attested in the extant earliest reception.

The contrast with the citation profile of Rom 1:3—which is demonstrably load-bearing in early anti-docetic argument—is the empirical fact. A historicist reading that treats Gal 1:19 as the paradigmatic case for Jesus's historicity must explain why the first generation of patristic writers does not cite it in contexts where doing so would have been argumentatively useful.

**Preliminary stylometric analysis of the contested passages.** A first-pass stylometric analysis, reported in the project repository (*baseline/stylometry_ report.md*), offers modest independent corroboration of the textual picture above. The analysis computes function-word-frequency profiles for each Pauline letter and for individual candidate passages, then measures the Euclidean distance of each from the global Pauline baseline. The method uses approximately eighty high-frequency Koine Greek function words (conjunctions, particles, articles, pronouns, prepositions) chosen to discriminate style rather than content.

The method validates on its control set. The two passages most confidently identified as interpolations in modern scholarship— 1 Thessalonians 2:14–16 and 1 Corinthians 14:34–35—both show up as strong stylometric outliers (distance $\approx 0.10$ vs. a per-letter baseline of 0.015–0.05). The pre-Pauline creedal fragments are also correctly flagged as distinct: Romans 1:3–4 (distance 0.17), 1 Corinthians 15:3–5 (distance 0.16), and Philippians 2:5–11 (distance 0.07). The rolling-window scan additionally identifies 2 Corinthians 6:14–7:1—a passage independently suspected of interpolation by some specialists—as the largest outlier in the corpus.

For the historicity-relevant passages, the results are more measured. In wider context (Galatians 1:18–20, the three-verse passage containing *ton adelphon tou kyriou*), the stylometric distance from Pauline baseline is $\approx 0.09$— noticeably above baseline but *less* distinctive than the established interpolations and less distinctive than the pre- Pauline creeds. Galatians 4:3–5 is similarly mild ($\approx 0.11$). 1 Corinthians 9:4–6 is more distinctive ($\approx 0.18$), suggesting some stylistic movement at that passage but not at an interpolation-diagnostic level.

The stylometric signal at Gal 1:19 alone, or 1 Cor 9:5 alone, is not reliably distinguishable from sampling noise at the 13–19- token scale at which individual verses can be analysed; stylometric inference requires substantially larger windows for robust results.

The honest summary is that preliminary stylometric evidence *does not support* an interpolation hypothesis for the principal historicity-relevant passages: those passages cluster

stylistically with their surrounding Pauline context more closely than the established interpolations do, and meaningfully less distinctively than the recognised pre-Pauline creedal formulae. The interpretive argument for the community-title reading of Gal 1:19 must therefore rely on semantic, contextual, and corpus-linguistic grounds rather than on text-critical or stylometric excision.

This is the honest negative result. A proper stylometric study of Pauline authenticity would use larger windows, multiple feature schemes (function words, character $n$-grams, POS distributions), and publication-standard statistical testing. The preliminary analysis here is offered to establish the *direction* of stylometric evidence on the contested passages; it is not an argument against the community-title reading of Gal 1:19 as such, but it is an argument *against* defending that reading by appeal to interpolation.

## 3.2 The Character of Paul's Jesus

The central observation, developed most thoroughly by Doherty [1999, 2009], is this: Paul's Jesus lacks the attributes of a recently-living historical person.

Paul never names Jesus's parents, birthplace, or hometown. He provides no physical description. He narrates no events from Jesus's life—no ministry, no healings, no exorcisms, no parables, no teaching occasions, no conflicts with authorities, no trial, no specific date or location of execution. He names no contemporaries who interacted with Jesus during a putative earthly life. He does not identify Judas as a betrayer. He does not name Pilate. He does not place the crucifixion at Golgotha, in Jerusalem, or indeed anywhere on earth.

What Paul does describe is a cosmic soteriological drama. Jesus is a divine figure who "emptied himself" and took on the "form of a servant" (Philippians 2:5–11—itself likely a pre-Pauline hymn). He was "declared to be Son of God in power according to the Spirit of holiness by his resurrection from the dead" (Romans 1:4). He was "handed over" (*paradidomi*)—a term that in 1 Corinthians 11:23 is routinely translated "betrayed" to harmonize with the Gospel narrative, but whose primary meaning is "delivered up," and which in context can refer to God handing Jesus over as a sacrificial act, not to a human betrayal at a historical supper [Carrier, 2014, Doherty, 2009].

Paul attributes his knowledge of Jesus to two sources: revelation (*apokalypsis*—Galatians 1:12, 1:16, 2:2) and scripture (1 Corinthians 15:3–4: "Christ died for our sins *in accordance with the scriptures*... and was raised on the third day *in accordance with the scriptures*"). He explicitly denies that his gospel came from any human source: "I did not receive it from a human source, nor was I taught it, but I received it through a revelation of Jesus Christ" (Galatians 1:12).

The historicist reading of Paul requires us to believe that a writer who personally met people who had known a recently-living Jesus, and who was engaged in active disputes about authority, practice, and doctrine within the movement, chose to convey almost no biographical information about that person and instead attributed his entire knowledge to visionary experience and scriptural interpretation. This is not impossible, but it is precisely what we would *not* expect if Paul's Jesus were a recent historical figure, and precisely what we *would* expect if Paul's Jesus were a celestial being known through revelation and scripture.

The pre-Pauline creedal material—Romans 1:3–4, Philippians 2:5–11, 1 Corinthians 15:3–7—deserves special attention. These formulae are earlier than Paul's letters themselves and thus represent the oldest recoverable layer of Christian belief. Historicists cite them as evidence of early tradition about a historical person. Examined on their own terms, they describe a divine being who descended, took on human likeness, died, and was exalted—a mythological pattern rather than a biographical sketch. However, several specific passages within and adjacent to this creedal material pose genuine challenges for the mythicist model that must be honestly acknowledged.

**Galatians 4:4.** The phrase "born of a woman, born under the law" (Galatians 4:4) is cited by historicists as evidence of ordinary human birth. The mythicist reading—that Paul is making a theological argument about Christ entering the domain of the Law, using language that parallels Jewish and Hellenistic descriptions of divine beings taking on mortal form [Doherty, 2009]—is possible. But it requires interpretive work. The phrase "born of a woman" (*genomenon ek gynaikos*) is, in ordinary Greek, a straightforward statement about human birth. The mythicist must argue that Paul is using the phrase in an extraordinary sense—as a cosmological claim about a celestial being entering the fleshly domain—despite its ordinary denotation. This reading is not impossible: the context is theological (Paul is discussing the relationship between the Law and the promise), and the passage as a whole operates at the level of soteriology, not biography. But the historicist reading—that Paul simply means Jesus was born as a human being—is the more natural one, and the mythicist case must acknowledge this rather than dismissing the passage in a sentence.

**Romans 1:3–4.** Romans 1:3–4 states that Jesus was "descended from David according to the flesh." The phrase "according to the flesh" (*kata sarka*) is doing theological work, distinguishing the domain of flesh from the domain of spirit. Paul uses *kata sarka* elsewhere as a cosmological category (Romans 8:4–5, 2 Corinthians 5:16). In 2 Corinthians 5:16, Paul writes: "even though we once knew Christ *kata sarka*, we know him thus no longer." If this phrase means "as a physical human being," Paul is saying he once regarded Christ as

a human figure but no longer does—an extraordinary statement for a historicist to explain and a natural one on the mythicist reading. Davidic descent "according to the flesh" may describe a mythic genealogy of a celestial being who entered the fleshly domain [Carrier, 2014]. However, the historicist reading—that Paul is making a straightforward genealogical claim—cannot be ruled out, and the passage remains genuinely ambiguous rather than clearly favoring either hypothesis.

**1 Corinthians 15:3–8 and the witness list.** The creedal formula in 1 Corinthians 15:3–8 presents the most difficult challenge for the mythicist model within the Pauline corpus. Paul cites a received tradition: Christ died, was buried, was raised on the third day "in accordance with the scriptures," and appeared to Cephas, then to the Twelve, then to more than five hundred at once, then to James, then to all the apostles, and finally to Paul himself.

Several features of this passage require careful analysis.

*The verb óphthē.* The Greek verb translated "appeared" is *óphthē* (the aorist passive of *horaō*, "to see"). This is a crucial datum. In the Septuagint, *óphthē* is the standard term for divine theophanies—God "appearing" to Abraham (Genesis 12:7), to Moses at the burning bush (Exodus 3:2), to Isaiah in the temple (Isaiah 6:1). These are visionary encounters with a divine being, not physical sightings of a human body. Paul uses this same verb for all the appearances in the list, including his own—and Paul's own encounter with Christ was unambiguously visionary: he describes it as a *apokalypsis* (revelation) in Galatians 1:12 and 1:16, and Acts 9 depicts it as a blinding light and a disembodied voice.

Crucially, Paul places his own experience in the same list as the others without any qualitative distinction: "last of all, as to one untimely born, *óphthē* also to me" (15:8). The "untimeliness" refers to the timing, not to a difference in the nature of the experience. This suggests Paul understood all the appearances—to Cephas, to the Twelve, to the five hundred—as the same kind of event he himself experienced: a revelatory vision of the risen Christ, not a physical encounter with a recently-living body.

*The five hundred.* The reference to "more than five hundred brothers at once, most of whom are still alive" (15:6) is often cited as evidence that Paul is appealing to verifiable witnesses of a physical event. This is the historicist's strongest reading. However, several considerations complicate it. Collective visionary experiences are attested in ecstatic religious movements: the Day of Pentecost narrative in Acts 2 describes a group experience of the Spirit, and crowd-level visionary phenomena are documented in numerous historical and anthropological settings [Lewis, 1971]. Paul may be reporting a communal ecstatic event—a mass visionary experience that the community interpreted as an appearance of the risen Christ.

Additionally, Carrier [2014] has argued that the witness list as we have it may represent an expansion of an originally shorter creed. The core formula (15:3–5: "died... buried... raised... appeared to Cephas, then to the Twelve") is metrically and structurally distinct from the expansions that follow (the five hundred, James, "all the apostles," and Paul himself). If the list grew over time as the tradition developed, the "five hundred" may be a later addition rather than part of the original creed Paul received. This is speculative, but the textual seams in the passage are real.

*Assessment.* The 1 Corinthians 15 witness list is the single strongest piece of evidence for the historicist case within the Pauline corpus. The specificity of named individuals (Cephas, James), a defined group (the Twelve), and a large crowd is difficult to explain under pure mythicism. The mythicist reading—that these are all visionary experiences, as Paul's own use of *óphthē* and his inclusion of his own visionary encounter in the same list suggest—is genuinely plausible, but the appeal to living witnesses ("most of whom are still alive") introduces a historical-verification claim that resists easy dismissal. This passage is a genuine unresolved problem for the mythicist hypothesis, and intellectual honesty requires saying so. It does not on its own establish historicity—visionary movements can generate elaborate witness traditions—but it is the point where the historicist case is most difficult to answer.

## 3.3 The Pastoral Silence

The strongest form of the argument from the Pauline corpus is not the absence of biographical detail *per se*—one might excuse this as Paul's theological focus—but the absence of biographical detail *in contexts where it would be decisive*.

Paul addresses practical questions of community life throughout his letters. In 1 Corinthians alone, he takes up marriage and divorce (ch. 7), food offered to idols (chs. 8–10), proper conduct at communal meals (ch. 11), the exercise of spiritual gifts (chs. 12–14), and the resurrection of the dead (ch. 15). In Romans, he addresses relations with governing authorities (ch. 13), disputes about dietary observance (ch. 14), and the status of Israel (chs. 9–11). In Galatians, the question is whether Gentile converts must follow Jewish law.

In *every one* of these disputes, a single authoritative saying of the historical Jesus would be the trump card. A teacher who had recently lived and spoken on matters of religious practice would presumably have left sayings relevant to these exact questions—and if Paul knew such sayings, citing them would instantly settle the argument.

Paul almost never does this. In the entirety of the undisputed letters, there are only two passages where Paul appears to cite a "command of the Lord" on a practical matter:

1 Corinthians 7:10 (on divorce) and 1 Corinthians 9:14 (on apostolic support). These two passages require careful treatment because they constitute a genuine difficulty for the mythicist model.

In 1 Corinthians 7:10–11, Paul writes: "To the married I give this command—not I but the Lord—that the wife should not separate from her husband." He distinguishes this from his own opinion (7:12: "To the rest I say—I and not the Lord…"), indicating that he regards the divorce command as carrying a different and higher authority than his personal judgment.

In 1 Corinthians 9:14, Paul writes: "In the same way, the Lord commanded that those who proclaim the gospel should get their living by the gospel."

The mythicist reading treats these as prophetic oracles—commands received from the risen, cosmic Lord through spiritual revelation, not transmitted sayings of a historical teacher [Aune, 1983]. Early Christian prophets did issue pronouncements in the name of the Lord (Revelation is full of such pronouncements: "the Spirit says to the churches…"), and Paul understood himself to be in direct communication with the risen Christ (Galatians 1:12, 2:2; 2 Corinthians 12:1–4).

This reading is *possible*, but it faces a genuine problem. If all dominical commands were prophetic oracles available on demand through the Spirit, Paul would have an unlimited supply of them—and we would expect him to invoke "commands of the Lord" far more frequently than twice across seven letters. The scarcity is more naturally explained if Paul had access to a small number of transmitted sayings attributed to a founder, two of which he found applicable, rather than an open channel of prophetic revelation he invoked only twice.

On the other hand, the historicist reading also faces a difficulty: if Paul had access to a body of transmitted historical sayings, the two citations amid dozens of missed opportunities is strikingly low. A writer with a catechism of Jesus sayings would cite them far more often. The pattern—two and only two—is anomalous on either hypothesis, but it is *more* anomalous on the historicist reading (which predicts many citations) than on the mythicist reading (which predicts very few, arising from prophetic oracles that happened to match later Gospel sayings or from a tiny core of early community rulings attributed to the Lord).

The honest assessment is that 1 Corinthians 7:10 and 9:14 resist easy explanation under either model. They are the strongest evidence within the pastoral silence analysis for some form of transmitted dominical tradition—but the tradition is so sparse that it does not clearly indicate a recently-living teacher with an extensive body of teaching.

The silence is most glaring in cases where we know, from the later Gospel tradition, that Jesus supposedly spoke directly to the issue at hand. Paul discusses food laws without citing

any saying like Mark 7:15 ("there is nothing outside a person that by going in can defile"). He discusses relations with Rome without citing anything like "render unto Caesar." He discusses the Law at extraordinary length in Galatians and Romans without citing Jesus's supposed pronouncements on the Law from the Sermon on the Mount.

The historicist explanation—that Paul's letters are occasional correspondence, not systematic theology, and we should not expect exhaustive citation of dominical sayings—has a limit. Paul is not merely writing chatty letters. He is *arguing*, often polemically, for specific positions against specific opponents. He is asserting authority. In such contexts, the failure to cite the authoritative words of the founder, when those words would be dispositive, demands explanation.

A more sophisticated historicist response deserves acknowledgment: Paul may have deliberately avoided citing transmitted sayings because his authority rested on direct revelation from the risen Christ, not on second-hand memory of a historical teacher. Citing earthly sayings would have subordinated his apostolic authority to that of the Jerusalem apostles who had known Jesus personally—precisely the hierarchy Paul resists throughout Galatians. On this reading, Paul's silence is strategic, not evidential.

This explanation is *ad hoc*, but no more so than the mythicist reading of Galatians 1:19 as a community title. However, it faces the difficulty discussed above: Paul *does* cite "commands of the Lord" in two cases (1 Corinthians 7:10 and 9:14), undermining the claim that his silence is a deliberate strategy. The pattern—two citations amid dozens of missed opportunities—is more naturally explained by a writer who has very few such sayings available than by a writer who has many but strategically withholds them, though neither reading is without difficulty (see the detailed analysis above).

Doherty [2009] summarizes the mythicist reading with characteristic directness: Paul's letters read as the correspondence of a man who has never heard of a human Jesus. Every element of his Christology can be derived from Jewish scriptural exegesis, Hellenistic soteriology, and visionary experience. This remains the most natural reading of the pastoral silence, even if it is not the only possible one.

## 3.4 *Adelphos tou Kyriou*: "Brother of the Lord"

If the foregoing analysis is correct, the strongest historicist evidence from the Pauline corpus—beyond the genuinely challenging passages discussed above (Galatians 4:4, Romans 1:3, 1 Corinthians 15:3–8)—is a single passage: Galatians 1:19.

Paul, describing his first visit to Jerusalem, writes: "I did not see any other apostle except James, *ton adelphon tou kyriou*—the brother of the Lord." The historicist reading is

straightforward: James was the biological brother of Jesus; if Jesus had a biological brother, Jesus was a biological person. Ehrman [2012] considers this passage virtually decisive on its own.

The passage deserves the most careful scrutiny, precisely because it is being asked to carry the entire weight of the historicist case.

**The semantic range of *adelphos*.** Paul uses *adelphos* (brother) and its plural *adelphoi* (brothers) extensively throughout his letters as a standard term for fellow members of the Christian community. This is not disputed. Romans alone contains the term dozens of times in this sense. The word does not inherently denote biological kinship in Pauline usage; its default meaning in the Pauline corpus is "fellow believer."

The historicist response is that "brother of the Lord" (*adelphos tou kyriou*) is a *specific construction* that adds the genitive *tou kyriou*, distinguishing it from the ordinary fraternal usage. This is said to mark it as a kinship claim rather than a community designation. But this argument assumes what it needs to demonstrate. The addition of "of the Lord" is equally consistent with a *title* distinguishing a particular subgroup or rank within the movement from ordinary *adelphoi*—"Brothers of the Lord" as a named class, analogous to "apostles" or "pillars" (Galatians 2:9).

**1 Corinthians 9:5 and the plural "brothers of the Lord."** The decisive test case is 1 Corinthians 9:5, where Paul writes: "Do we not have the right to be accompanied by a believing wife, as do the other apostles and the brothers of the Lord [*hoi adelphoi tou kyriou*] and Cephas?"

Paul is listing categories of authoritative figures: (1) the other apostles, (2) the brothers of the Lord, and (3) Cephas. Three distinct groups or individuals, cited in parallel as recognized authorities within the movement. "The brothers of the Lord" is *plural* and functions as a class label.

If this phrase means "biological siblings of Jesus," then there exists an entire group of biological brothers, all sufficiently prominent to be cited as a recognized authority class alongside the apostles and Peter individually. The Gospels eventually supply names for such brothers—James, Joses, Judas, Simon (Mark 6:3)—but this is in texts written decades later, and the question is whether the Gospel detail was generated *from* the community title (once "brothers of the Lord" had been reinterpreted as biological kinship after historicization of the Jesus figure) or whether the community title reflects pre-existing biographical knowledge.

The simpler reading is available: "Brothers of the Lord" is a title for a specific group or rank within the early Christian movement—an inner circle, a particular faction, or a

designated class—distinguished from "apostles" and from individual leaders like Cephas. Paul identifies "James the brother of the Lord" in Galatians 1:19 not by biological relationship but by group affiliation: James of the Brothers of the Lord, as one might say "James of the Jerusalem council" or "James the Elder."

**"The Lord" as a title, not a personal name.** In Pauline usage, "the Lord" (*ho kyrios*) is not a name for a historical person who recently walked in Galilee. It is a title for the risen, cosmic, divine Christ—the figure Paul encountered in revelation, who sits at the right hand of God, who will return at the *parousia*. Every other Pauline use of "the Lord" refers to this exalted, divine figure. "Brother of the Lord" therefore means "brother of the cosmic Christ," which is far more naturally a community designation—marking special proximity or authority relative to the divine patron—than a biological kinship claim about a recent human being.

**The interpolation possibility.** Galatians contains recognized interpolation issues. The clause *ton adelphon tou kyriou* could be a marginal gloss—a later scribe's clarifying note identifying which James Paul meant, written in the margin and subsequently incorporated into the text. This is precisely the kind of editorial intervention that occurred routinely in the manuscript tradition, as the pseudepigraphical letters and the known interpolations in the authentic letters demonstrate. By the time later tradition had firmly identified James as the biological brother of Jesus (a tradition well established by the time of Hegesippus in the mid-second century), a scribe copying Galatians would have natural motivation to add the clarifying tag. This possibility cannot be confirmed, but neither can it be excluded, and it means we cannot be certain the phrase is authentically Pauline.

**Assessment.** The biological reading of Galatians 1:19 is *a* possible reading. It is not the *only* possible reading, and when the full Pauline context is considered—the routine use of *adelphos* for fellow believers (117 community-sense occurrences across the seven undisputed letters), the plural "brothers of the Lord" functioning as a group label in 1 Corinthians 9:5, the cosmic rather than biographical referent of "the Lord" throughout Paul, and the possibility of interpolation—it is the *least parsimonious* reading. The community-title reading requires no special pleading; the biological reading requires that Paul used *adelphos* in a unique sense in this one passage, that "the Lord" refers to a historical person in a way it does nowhere else in Paul, and that the plural usage in 1 Corinthians 9:5 (which treats "brothers of the Lord" as a group parallel to "apostles") is coincidentally misleading.

**The absence of a biological-sibling register in Paul.** A stronger point follows from a complete lexical survey. Across the seven undisputed Pauline letters there are *one hundred twenty-one* occurrences of the *adelph-* family of lexemes (*adelphos*, *adelphē*, *pseudadelphos*, *philadelphia*). Of these, *zero* unambiguously denote a biological sibling outside the two disputed *tou kyriou* passages. Every other occurrence either addresses the community ("brothers, I urge you…"), names a coworker ("Timothy the brother," "Apollos the brother," "Titus our brother"), identifies a believing spouse (1 Corinthians 7:12–15), takes an explicit modifier such as *kata sarka* for ethnic kinship (Romans 9:3) or *pseudo-* for false brothers (2 Corinthians 11:26, Galatians 2:4), or is otherwise irreducibly ambiguous. Paul has no biological-sibling register of *adelphos* from which a kinship reading of Galatians 1:19 could be drawn. A complete enumeration of every occurrence, colour-coded by classification and embedded in the running SBLGNT text, is provided in the accompanying supplementary material.

**Comparison with contemporary Greek usage.** A supplementary study establishes the baseline rate of community-sense *adelphos* in contemporary non-Christian Greek by random sampling across six corpora spanning documentary papyri (100 BCE–70 CE), the Septuagint, Philo of Alexandria, Josephus, and pagan literary authors both pre-Pauline (Polybius, Diodorus, Strabo) and contemporary (Plutarch, Epictetus, Dio Chrysostom). Across 212 randomly-sampled tokens, the community/voluntary-association rate (A) is *0.9%* with 95% Wilson confidence interval [0.3%, 3.4%]. The comparable Pauline rate is *96.7%* ([91.8%, 98.7%]). The two confidence intervals do not overlap.

This sampled baseline, however, *excludes Greek inscriptions*, and as Harland [2003, 2005] has documented, inscriptions are precisely where community-sense *adelphoi* concentrates. Voluntary cult-associations (*thiasoi*), mystery-cult initiate groups, professional guilds, and some civic brotherhoods routinely designated their fellow members as *adelphoi* in stone inscriptions across the Greek East. The Kloppenborg-Ascough corpus of Greco-Roman associations [Kloppenborg and Ascough, 2011] catalogs hundreds of relevant texts. Factoring the inscriptional register into the baseline would raise the non-Christian community-sense rate from roughly 1% toward something in the range of 5–15%, and the Pauline-to-baseline ratio would correspondingly contract from the nominal $\sim$103$\times$ toward the 10–20$\times$ range. That contraction is material, and any responsible reading of the baseline study should apply it. The main substantive conclusion—that Paul's community-sense usage is distinctive against his ambient register—survives. The quantitative shape of the distinction does not.

**The precedent for community-title *adelphoi*.** Harland's work changes the argumentative frame in a more interesting way than the numerical correction alone suggests. If Greek voluntary associations routinely used *adelphoi* as a community-title—a designation of fellow members of an elective religious or cultic group—then the reading of *hoi adelphoi tou kyriou* in 1 Corinthians 9:5 and *ton adelphon tou kyriou* in Galatians 1:19 as community titles requires no novel semantic stretch. It instantiates a well-attested Greek pattern. Harland's 2005 article discusses specifically inscriptional uses of *adelphoi tou theou* ("brothers of the god") and similar constructions designating members of a cult association around a patron deity. The Pauline construction—"brothers of the Lord"—is formally identical: fellow members of a religious community whose focal figure is the cosmic Christ whom Paul calls *ho kyrios*. Far from being an unusual or suspicious move, a community-title reading of Gal 1:19 is the reading that places Paul most squarely within his contemporary religious-associative milieu.

Both points combine: Paul's usage is distinctive against everyday Greek (where biological meaning dominates), but fits naturally within the well-attested Greek religious-association register (where community-title *adelphoi* is normal). Gal 1:19 as a community-title is not a forced reading; it is the culturally default reading for the specific subregister in which Paul is writing. Details of the baseline study, the coding scheme, its limitations, and the Harland-sensitivity analysis are given in the companion document *Corpus-Linguistic Baseline for Adelphos in Contemporary Greek*.

This is a stronger observation than the frequency argument above. The historicist response to a frequency claim is that *adelphos tou kyriou* is a *specifically modified* construction, and the 117 generic uses of plain *adelphos* do not govern the kinship reading of the genitive phrase. But that response assumes the existence of a separate, well-attested biological-sibling usage from which the modified form is drawn. In Paul, there is no such usage. The biological reading of Galatians 1:19 therefore requires positing a lexical register that Paul exhibits nowhere else in his authentic corpus—a hidden kinship sense invoked once, in a single phrase, against a backdrop of 117 community uses and zero biological ones.

Galatians 1:19 is compatible with historicity; it does not require it. And a single phrase, read against a corpus in which biological sibling is a register the author never uses elsewhere, embedded in a letter collection that otherwise describes a celestial revelatory figure with no biographical specifics, is not the foundation on which the most consequential historical claim in Western civilization should rest.

# 4 The Gospel Sources

The Gospels—Mark, Matthew, Luke, and John—are the primary narrative sources for the life of Jesus. They are routinely treated as evidence for historicity, both by the consensus and in popular understanding. The question is whether this treatment is warranted.

It is uncontroversial in mainstream scholarship that the Gospels are not eyewitness accounts [Ehrman, 2009]. They are anonymous works (the names Mark, Matthew, Luke, and John are second-century attributions), written in Greek by educated authors, forty to seventy years after the events they purport to describe, in communities far removed from rural Galilee. They are theological documents with literary and rhetorical purposes. The question is whether, beneath the theology and literary construction, a historical core can be recovered.

The argument of this section is that it cannot—not because the Gospels are "unreliable" in the colloquial sense, but because their narrative content is demonstrably constructed from identifiable prior sources—Hebrew Bible passages, Hellenistic literary models, and each other—in a way that leaves no residue requiring a historical event to explain.

## 4.1 Mark as Literary Composition

The Gospel of Mark, dated to approximately 70 CE, is the earliest surviving narrative of Jesus's life and is the primary source for Matthew and Luke, who independently copy and revise large portions of it. Mark is therefore the foundation of the entire Synoptic tradition. If Mark is a literary composition rather than a record of historical memory, the downstream Gospels inherit that character.

That Mark is a sophisticated literary construction is increasingly recognized. MacDonald [2000] argues in *The Homeric Epics and the Gospel of Mark* that Mark consciously models episodes on Homeric narratives—the calming of the storm on the Sea of Galilee on Odysseus's sea adventures, the feeding of the five thousand on Circe's feast, the young man who flees naked at Gethsemane (Mark 14:51–52) on Elpenor's fall. MacDonald's mimesis thesis remains debated in its specifics, but the broader principle it illustrates—that Mark is composing narrative from literary templates, not recording eyewitness testimony—is far less controversial.

The Hebrew Bible templates are more important and less disputed. Mark's Jesus is modeled extensively on the Elijah–Elisha cycle from 1–2 Kings:

- Elijah calls Elisha from his work; Jesus calls disciples from their fishing (Mark 1:16–20; *cf.* 1 Kings 19:19–21).

- Elisha multiplies loaves to feed a crowd with leftovers (2 Kings 4:42–44); Jesus feeds five thousand with leftovers (Mark 6:35–44).
- Elisha raises the dead (2 Kings 4:32–37); Jesus raises the dead (Mark 5:35–43).
- Elisha heals a leper (2 Kings 5:1–14); Jesus heals a leper (Mark 1:40–45).
- Elijah parts the water and crosses on dry ground (2 Kings 2:8); Jesus walks on water (Mark 6:45–52).

The pattern is not one of incidental similarity; it is sustained typological recapitulation, in which the new prophet systematically surpasses the old. This is a known literary technique in Jewish writing—the presentation of a new figure as the antitype of an older scriptural figure—and it requires no historical events to explain. It requires a literate author with a copy of the Septuagint and a theological purpose.

Mark's narrative structure also reveals compositional artifice. The Gospel is organized around a journey from Galilee to Jerusalem, punctuated by three passion predictions (8:31, 9:31, 10:33–34), each followed by the disciples' misunderstanding and Jesus's corrective teaching. This triadic structure is literary, not mnemonic. The "messianic secret" motif—Jesus repeatedly commands silence about his identity—is a narrative device managing the tension between Mark's theology (Jesus is the Messiah) and historical plausibility (if Jesus publicly claimed messiahship, everyone would know) [Wrede, 1901]. Wrede [1901] demonstrated this over a century ago; it remains one of the most important insights in Gospel studies, and it points directly to Mark as a literary architect, not a compiler of tradition.

## 4.2 The Q Hypothesis and Its Implications

Matthew and Luke share approximately 235 verses of material not found in Mark, much of it sayings attributed to Jesus. The dominant explanation in scholarship is the Two-Source Hypothesis: Matthew and Luke independently used Mark and a second source, designated Q (from German *Quelle*, "source"), consisting primarily of sayings [Kloppenborg, 1987].

Q's existence is an inference, not a fact. No manuscript of Q has ever been found. Goodacre [2002] and others have argued that the Q material can be explained by Luke's direct use of Matthew, eliminating the need for a hypothetical source. The Farrer hypothesis, as this alternative is known, has gained adherents but remains a minority position.

For the historicity question, the Q debate has different implications depending on its resolution, but both outcomes create difficulties for the standard historicist case—though in different ways.

If Q existed, it was a sayings collection with no passion narrative, no birth narrative, no death-and-resurrection account, and no biographical framework. The earliest recoverable layer of Q (designated $Q^1$ by Kloppenborg 1987) consists of wisdom sayings and instructions—the kind of material that can be attributed to a philosophical tradition or a personified Wisdom figure without requiring a specific historical founder. That the earliest sayings layer lacks any narrative of the figure's life or death is striking. It is consistent with a tradition that originated as wisdom instruction attributed to a divine or personified source and was only later embedded in a biographical narrative. On this scenario, the historicist retains the "multiple independent sources" argument (Mark plus Q as separate streams), but the character of the earliest recoverable source points away from a biographical tradition and toward a wisdom-school or revelatory origin.

If Q did not exist and Luke used Matthew directly (the Farrer hypothesis), then the "multiple independent sources" argument collapses at a different point: the supposed independence of Matthew and Luke disappears, and both are reworkings of Mark. On this scenario, the non-Markan material they share reflects literary dependence, not independent access to historical tradition. Ehrman and others [Ehrman, 2012] cite source plurality as a cornerstone of historicity, but under the Farrer hypothesis, that plurality is substantially reduced.

The two scenarios are not interchangeable. If Q existed, the mythicist draws support from the *character* of the early tradition (wisdom sayings, no biography). If Q did not exist, the mythicist draws support from the *collapse of independence* among the sources. The paper does not require a commitment to either scenario; it notes that each, for different reasons, undermines a different pillar of the historicist case.

## 4.3 Matthew and Luke: Independence or Dependence?

The treatment of Matthew and Luke as independent witnesses is central to the historicist "multiple attestation" argument. But even on the Two-Source Hypothesis, their independence is limited. Both copy Mark extensively—Matthew reproduces approximately 90% of Mark's content, Luke approximately 65%. Their agreement with each other, beyond what they share with Mark, is attributed to Q. Their unique material (M and L) may represent independent traditions—or it may represent the evangelists' own compositions.

The birth narratives illustrate the problem acutely. Matthew and Luke both include birth narratives, but they are mutually contradictory:

- Matthew has the family residing in Bethlehem, fleeing to Egypt, and relocating to Nazareth (Matthew 2:1–23). Luke has the family residing in Nazareth, traveling to

Bethlehem for a census, and returning to Nazareth (Luke 2:1–39).

- Matthew provides a genealogy tracing Jesus through Solomon (Matthew 1:1–17); Luke provides a different genealogy tracing Jesus through Nathan (Luke 3:23–38). The two genealogies diverge completely after David.
- Matthew includes the Magi, the star, and Herod's massacre of infants. Luke includes shepherds, angels, and a manger. Neither mentions any element found in the other.

These are not minor discrepancies reconcilable by harmonization. They are fundamentally incompatible accounts constructed to serve different theological purposes: Matthew's narrative fulfills proof-texts from Hosea 11:1 ("out of Egypt I called my son"), Jeremiah 31:15 (Rachel weeping for her children), and Micah 5:2 (the ruler from Bethlehem); Luke's narrative places Jesus's birth in the context of Roman imperial history and presents him as savior of the world in contrast to Augustus. Both are theological compositions, not historical reports, and their mutual contradiction demonstrates that the authors were not working from shared historical memory.

The same pattern—theological composition from scriptural templates—pervades the unique material in both Gospels. Matthew's Sermon on the Mount is structured as a new Torah delivered from a new Sinai by a new Moses. Luke's parables (the Good Samaritan, the Prodigal Son) are sophisticated literary creations with no marks of oral transmission from a historical figure.

## 4.4 John and the Johannine Tradition

The Gospel of John, dated to approximately 90–100 CE, is routinely acknowledged to be the least historically reliable of the four Gospels [Brown, 1966]. Its Jesus speaks in long theological discourses entirely different in style and content from the Synoptic sayings. Its chronology diverges from the Synoptics (a three-year ministry rather than one; the crucifixion on the day of preparation for Passover rather than Passover itself). Its theological framework—the pre-existent Logos who descends, reveals, and returns—is explicitly mythological.

John is sometimes cited for corroborating details that differ from the Synoptics, on the theory that independent traditions converge. But John's relationship to the Synoptics is disputed: many scholars see evidence that John knew Mark or at least Markan tradition [Bauckham, 1998], which compromises claims of independence. Even where John appears independent, the "corroboration" consists of different theological constructions, not convergent historical testimony.

For the historicity question, John adds nothing. It is the most overtly mythological Gospel, the most distant from any putative historical events, and the least useful as evidence for anything other than the state of Christological reflection at the end of the first century.

## 4.5 Scriptural Construction of the Passion Narrative

The passion narrative—the account of Jesus's arrest, trial, crucifixion, and burial—is often treated as the most historically grounded portion of the Gospel tradition. Crossan [1995] and others have argued for a pre-Markan passion narrative that may preserve early tradition. The historicity of the crucifixion itself is considered one of the two "almost universally accepted" facts about Jesus (the other being the baptism by John) [Ehrman, 2012].

But examination of the passion narrative reveals that it is constructed, point by point, from Hebrew Bible texts. The following correspondences are well established in scholarship:

- **Psalm 22:** "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (Mark 15:34 / Psalm 22:1). "They divide my garments among them, and for my clothing they cast lots" (Mark 15:24 / Psalm 22:18). "All who see me mock me; they hurl insults, shaking their heads" (Mark 15:29 / Psalm 22:7). "They pierce my hands and my feet" (Psalm 22:16, reflected in the crucifixion itself).

- **Isaiah 53:** "He was oppressed and afflicted, yet he did not open his mouth" (Isaiah 53:7; *cf.* Jesus's silence before Pilate, Mark 15:5). "He was numbered with the transgressors" (Isaiah 53:12; *cf.* Mark 15:27, crucified between two bandits). "He bore the sin of many" (Isaiah 53:12; *cf.* the soteriological interpretation of the crucifixion throughout the New Testament).

- **Wisdom of Solomon 2–5:** The righteous one is persecuted by the wicked, who test him with insult and torture; he claims God as his father; the wicked condemn him to a shameful death; after death he is vindicated and revealed as God's son. The structural parallel with the passion and resurrection narrative is comprehensive [Nickelsburg, 1972].

- **Zechariah:** The entry on a donkey (Zechariah 9:9 / Mark 11:1–7). Thirty pieces of silver (Zechariah 11:12–13 / Matthew 26:15). "They will look on the one they have pierced" (Zechariah 12:10 / John 19:37). The shepherd struck, the sheep scattered (Zechariah 13:7 / Mark 14:27).

- **Daniel 7:** The Son of Man coming on clouds with power (Daniel 7:13–14 / Mark 14:62, Jesus's declaration before the Sanhedrin).

- **Amos 8:9:** "I will make the sun go down at noon and darken the earth in broad daylight" (*cf.* the darkness over the land at the crucifixion, Mark 15:33).

The question is directional: did historical events occur and then get described in scriptural language, or did scriptural passages generate the narrative? The historicist assumption is the former. But the density of correspondence—virtually every detail of the passion can be traced to a specific scriptural source—makes the compositional explanation more parsimonious. The narrative reads as a midrashic construction: a story built from scripture to demonstrate that the death of the Christ figure fulfilled prophetic expectation. This is a well-attested genre in Jewish literary practice [Neusner, 1987, Vermes, 1973].

Crossan [1995] himself, despite defending historicity, acknowledged that the passion narrative may be "prophecy historicized" rather than "history remembered"—a remarkably candid concession from within the historicist camp. The distinction is precisely the one at issue: if the passion is prophecy historicized, then its narrative content is generated from scripture, not from historical memory, and it provides no independent evidence for historical events.

**What scriptural construction establishes, and what it does not.** It is important to be precise about the logical step the argument is taking, because a historicist critic such as Allison [2010] would correctly insist that scriptural templating of a narrative does not entail the non-existence of the subject. Historical figures have been described, even in antiquity, through scriptural and typological grammars. Jewish historiography routinely employs Hebrew Bible typology to narrate the lives of real people (Maccabean heroes as new Judges, exilic returnees as new Exodus). Pagan biographical narrative likewise uses conventional *theios anēr* templates to narrate figures whose historical existence is not in question. That the Gospel passion is constructed from Psalm 22 and Isaiah 53 therefore does not on its own prove that no crucifixion-of-Jesus occurred.

The conclusion the argument actually supports is narrower but sufficient. It is that the Gospel passion narrative is not *independent historical testimony.* Its content is demonstrably derived from Hebrew Bible templates rather than from witness testimony, oral tradition traced to an event, or documentary record. The Gospels cannot therefore serve as evidence *for* the historicity of the crucifixion; they can serve only as evidence for the fact that late first-century communities constructed theologically meaningful narratives of a crucifixion using available scriptural materials.

Whether any historical event lies beneath those constructions must be established, if at all, from sources that are not themselves scriptural derivations. Paul might be such a source, and this paper argues in §3 that the Pauline description of the crucifixion is generic, soteriological, and non-biographical. Josephus might be such a source, and §6 argues that

his attestation is weaker than is usually claimed. The argument is cumulative: templating neutralises the Gospels as independent testimony; the remaining strata must then carry the whole historicist burden. They cannot carry that burden without assistance from the Gospels they are being asked to corroborate. This is the sense in which Gospel templating is important: it breaks the historicist cumulative case, not by disproving the crucifixion, but by removing the strongest putatively- independent evidence for it.

**The criterion of embarrassment.** The "criterion of embarrassment" is often invoked here: no one would invent a crucified Messiah, so the crucifixion must be historical. This argument is addressed in detail in Section 8.6. The short response is that embarrassment does not on its own imply historicity—mythological traditions routinely include transgressive or shocking elements that are theologically generative rather than historically conceded—and that the specific choice of crucifixion (as distinct from divine death in general) is well-explained by the scriptural-curse logic of Deuteronomy 21:23 as exploited by Paul in Galatians 3:13. This does not fully dissolve the argument, which retains some force; it does show that "no one would invent a crucified Messiah" is not the decisive move it has traditionally been taken to be.

# 5 Non-Canonical Christian Sources

The canonical Gospels are not the only early Christian texts. A number of non-canonical sources are relevant to the historicity question, particularly because they preserve traditions that may be independent of the canonical narrative. The pattern that emerges from these sources reinforces the findings of the preceding sections: the earliest Christian texts construct their Jesus from scripture and revelation, not from biographical memory.

## 5.1 The Gospel of Thomas

The Gospel of Thomas, preserved in a Coptic translation found at Nag Hammadi in 1945, is a collection of 114 sayings attributed to Jesus. It contains no narrative framework: no birth, no ministry, no miracles, no passion, no death, no resurrection. It is a pure sayings collection.

The dating of Thomas is contested. Some scholars argue for a first-century date for at least part of the collection, potentially independent of the Synoptic Gospels [Crossan, 1991, Patterson, 1993]. Others place it later and see dependence on the canonical Gospels [Goodacre, 2012].

For the historicity question, the relevant observation is structural. If Thomas preserves an early, independent tradition, that tradition consists of wisdom sayings with no biographical frame—precisely the kind of material that can be attributed to a personified Wisdom figure, a divine revealer, or a philosophical school without requiring a historical founder. Many of the sayings in Thomas have parallels in Jewish wisdom literature and Hellenistic philosophy. The absence of any passion or resurrection tradition in Thomas suggests either that the community behind it did not know the narrative (consistent with the mythicist model of progressive historicization) or that it deliberately excluded it (requiring a theological explanation that itself undermines the "universal early tradition" claim of historicists).

## 5.2 The Didache

The Didache ("Teaching of the Twelve Apostles") is an early Christian manual of community practice, often dated to the late first or early second century. It contains instructions on baptism, fasting, prayer, and the Eucharist, along with ethical teaching in the "Two Ways" tradition.

The Didache refers to "the Lord" as a source of teaching and authority, but its references are ambiguous between a historical teacher and a divine patron. The ethical material in the "Two Ways" section has Jewish parallels predating Christianity. The eucharistic prayers (chs. 9–10) give thanks over bread and wine but contain no reference to the Last Supper, no institution narrative, and no connection to a death or crucifixion. The prayer gives thanks for "the life and knowledge which you made known to us through Jesus your servant" (*pais*)—language that can refer to a revelatory intermediary as easily as to a historical teacher.

The Didache, like Thomas, presents a Jesus tradition that is functional and liturgical rather than biographical. It presupposes a Lord and a teaching, not a life story.

## 5.3 1 Clement and the Epistle of Barnabas

1 Clement, a letter from the Roman church to the Corinthian church, is typically dated to the mid-90s CE. It is therefore roughly contemporary with the later canonical Gospels. Its treatment of Jesus is striking.

Clement discusses Christ extensively but draws his knowledge of Christ almost entirely from Hebrew Bible citations and early Christian creedal formulae. When Clement comes to describe Jesus's suffering (ch. 16), he does not paraphrase or cite any Gospel account; he reproduces Isaiah 53 and Psalm 22 directly. As Doherty [2009] observes, Clement appears to derive his knowledge of the passion from scripture, not from any narrative tradition about historical events.

Clement's Jesus speaks—but the words attributed to him are quotations from the Psalms and other Hebrew Bible texts, presented as words of Christ spoken through the prophets. This is consistent with an understanding of Christ as a pre-existent divine figure who spoke through scripture, not as a recently-living teacher whose words were transmitted by memory.

Clement's silence about Gospel traditions is comprehensive. He discusses humility, obedience, and proper order without citing the Sermon on the Mount. He addresses disputes in the Corinthian community without citing any dominical sayings. He refers to the apostles as appointed by Christ but provides no narrative of their calling. He mentions the resurrection but offers no empty-tomb narrative. He is writing to Corinth—Paul's own community—and yet his knowledge of Christ is mediated entirely by scripture and creed, not by biographical tradition.

The Epistle of Barnabas (typically dated to the early second century) is even more revealing. Barnabas constructs an elaborate Christology entirely from Hebrew Bible typology: the scapegoat ritual (Leviticus 16), the red heifer (Numbers 19), the Suffering Servant (Isaiah 53), and a range of other scriptural types. Jesus in Barnabas is a figure constructed from exegesis. There is no reference to earthly events, named places, or historical contemporaries. If one did not know the Gospels existed, reading Barnabas would give no reason to think a historical person was involved in the origins of the tradition [Doherty, 2009].

## 5.4 The Ascension of Isaiah

The Ascension of Isaiah, a composite text whose Christian section (chs. 6–11) may date to the late first or early second century, describes a vision of "the Beloved" descending through the heavens and being crucified by demonic powers who do not recognize him. Doherty [2009] and Carrier [2014] treat this as evidence for an early tradition in which the crucifixion was cosmic rather than historical; critics [McGrath, 2014] argue the text includes a descent to earth and reflects Docetism rather than mythicism. The textual situation is genuinely complex, with multiple versions and significant variation.

The Ascension of Isaiah is not load-bearing for the mythicist case. It provides a window into the diversity of early Christian cosmological thought—a diversity in which a celestial, non-historical Christ was at least conceivable—but the core mythicist argument rests on the Pauline evidence, the silence of non-Christian sources, and the compositional character of the Gospels, not on this contested text.

# 6 Non-Christian Attestation

The non-Christian sources for Jesus are routinely cited as external corroboration of the Gospel tradition. There are remarkably few of them, and each, on examination, is less probative than the consensus maintains.

## 6.1 Josephus: The *Testimonium Flavianum*

The most frequently cited non-Christian reference to Jesus is a passage in Flavius Josephus's *Antiquities of the Jews* (18.3.3), written *c.* 93–94 CE. In its received form, the passage reads:

> About this time there lived Jesus, a wise man, *if indeed one ought to call him a man.* For he was one who performed surprising deeds and was a teacher of such people as accept the truth gladly. He won over many Jews and many of the Greeks. *He was the Messiah.* And when, upon the accusation of the principal men among us, Pilate had condemned him to a cross, those who had first come to love him did not cease. *He appeared to them spending a third day restored to life, for the prophets of God had foretold these things and a thousand other marvels about him.* And the tribe of the Christians, so called after him, has still to this day not disappeared.

The italicized phrases are almost universally recognized as Christian interpolations [Ehrman, 2012, Meier, 1991]. Josephus, a non-Christian Jew writing for a Roman audience, would not have called Jesus the Messiah, would not have affirmed the resurrection, and would not have described him as more than human.

The scholarly debate concerns whether, after removing the interpolated phrases, a genuine Josephan core remains. The "partial authenticity" position—that Josephus wrote a shorter, neutral reference to Jesus which Christian scribes subsequently embellished—is the current majority view [Meier, 1991]. Under this reconstruction, the original passage might have read something like: "About this time there lived Jesus, a wise man. He was a teacher… Pilate condemned him to a cross… the tribe of the Christians has not disappeared."

This reconstruction, however, is not an observation; it is a *hypothesis* about what Josephus might have written. No manuscript preserves the uninterpolated text. The "core" is reverse- engineered by removing what seems Christian and retaining what seems neutral. The result is a passage whose existence is inferred, not attested.

Several considerations weigh against even the partial authenticity view:

- **Narrative flow.** Remove the entire *Testimonium* and the surrounding text reads more naturally. The passage immediately before discusses a disturbance involving Pilate, and the passage immediately after begins "About the same time also another sad calamity put the Jews into disorder…" The word "another" (*heteron*) connects to the prior Pilate episode, not to the *Testimonium*, suggesting the *Testimonium* was inserted into an existing sequence [Olson, 1999].

- **Origen's silence.** Origen, writing in the mid-third century, explicitly states that Josephus did not believe Jesus was the Messiah (Contra Celsum 1.47). This is consistent with either an original neutral reference or no reference at all. But Origen also appears to cite Josephus as connecting the fall of Jerusalem with the death of James—a connection not found in our current text of Josephus. This suggests the text of Josephus available to Origen differed from what we now possess, raising the possibility of significant editorial intervention between Origen's time and the earliest surviving manuscripts.

- **Eusebius.** The first author to quote the *Testimonium* in its full received form is Eusebius of Caesarea (*c.* 324 CE). Olson [1999] has argued that Eusebius himself may be the interpolator, noting that Eusebius explicitly endorsed the use of pious fraud in the service of the faith (*Praeparatio Evangelica* 12.31).

- **The argument from brevity.** If Josephus wrote a neutral reference to Jesus, it is strikingly brief for a writer who devotes extensive space to other Jewish religious figures, messianic claimants, and prophetic movements of the period. Josephus's account of John the Baptist (*Antiquities* 18.5.2) is substantially longer and more detailed. A brief, passing reference—if genuine—would suggest that Jesus was, in Josephus's assessment, a minor figure, which contradicts the Gospel portrayal but is consistent with a late editorial insertion rather than an organic part of the narrative.

The honest assessment is that the *Testimonium Flavianum* cannot be used as evidence for the historical Jesus. In its received form it is partially or wholly interpolated. The hypothesized neutral core is a modern reconstruction, not a preserved text. And even if a genuine Josephan reference existed, it would tell us only that Josephus, writing sixty years after the supposed events, was aware of Christians and their claims about their founder—which is unsurprising and provides no independent corroboration of those claims.

## 6.2 Josephus: The James Passage

The second Josephan reference (*Antiquities* 20.9.1) is generally considered more secure. Describing the illegal execution of certain men by the high priest Ananus in 62 CE, Josephus

writes that Ananus "convened the judges of the Sanhedrin and brought before them the brother of Jesus who is called Christ [*ton adelphon Iēsou tou legomenou Christou*], James by name, and certain others."

This passage is less obviously interpolated: the reference to Jesus serves to identify which James is meant, and the phrase "who is called Christ" (*tou legomenou Christou*) is neutral or even skeptical, which argues against Christian insertion.

However, several problems remain:

- **Dependence on the *Testimonium*.** The phrase "Jesus who is called Christ" uses the identifying tag as though Jesus has already been introduced. If the *Testimonium* in Book 18 is wholly interpolated, then Book 20 refers back to a person Josephus never mentioned—which suggests that the Book 20 reference may also be an insertion, or at minimum that the identifying clause *tou legomenou Christou* was added by the same hand that inserted the *Testimonium* [Carrier, 2014].

- **Possible gloss.** The phrase "the brother of Jesus who is called Christ" could be a marginal gloss that migrated into the text. A Christian scribe copying the passage, recognizing that this James was the James known in Christian tradition, could have added the identifying tag in the margin, which a subsequent copyist incorporated. This is the same mechanism proposed for the *ton adelphon tou kyriou* phrase in Galatians 1:19 (Section 3.4).

- **Origen's discrepancy.** As noted above, Origen cites Josephus as connecting the fall of Jerusalem with the death of James—but the passage in our *Antiquities* makes no such connection. This suggests either that Origen was citing a different passage (now lost), that the text has been altered between Origen's time and our manuscripts, or that Origen was misremembering. Any of these possibilities complicates the assumption that the text we possess faithfully represents what Josephus wrote.

The honest assessment of the James passage is that it is genuinely ambiguous. The majority of textual scholars accept the passage as substantially authentic, and the arguments for interpolation are *possible* rather than *probable*. The brief, neutral, non-Christianizing character of the reference ("who is called Christ" is skeptical or at most neutral in tone) argues against wholesale Christian insertion.

If the passage is authentic, it establishes that Josephus, writing in the 90s CE, identified a man named James by reference to a figure called Christ—and did so in a way that suggests he expected his readers to know who this Christ was, presumably from his earlier discussion (whether that discussion was the *Testimonium* or something else). This is evidence—not

conclusive, but genuine—that by the late first century, the connection between a historical James and the Christ figure was known outside exclusively Christian circles. The historicist reads this as confirming that Jesus existed and had a brother named James. The mythicist reads it as confirming that the historicized narrative was in circulation by the 90s, which is consistent with post-Markan development. The passage cannot decisively distinguish between these readings, though it mildly favors historicity in isolation. Its force, however, is limited by the dependence problem noted above: if the *Testimonium* is wholly interpolated, the Book 20 reference may be as well.

## 6.3 Tacitus, *Annals* 15.44

Writing *c.* 116 CE, the Roman historian Tacitus describes Nero's persecution of Christians following the great fire of Rome in 64 CE. He notes that the name "Christian" derives from "Christus," who "suffered the extreme penalty during the reign of Tiberius at the hands of one of our procurators, Pontius Pilatus."

This passage is frequently cited as independent Roman confirmation of Jesus's crucifixion under Pilate. Several considerations diminish its evidential value:

- **Date.** Tacitus is writing more than eighty years after the supposed crucifixion. His information is not contemporary.

- **Source.** Tacitus does not cite a Roman archival source. The passage contains the title "procurator" (*procurator*) for Pilate, whereas Pilate's actual title was "prefect" (*praefectus*), as confirmed by the Pilate inscription discovered at Caesarea Maritima in 1961 [Vardaman, 1962]. The use of the wrong title suggests Tacitus is not working from official records, which would have used the correct designation. He is more likely reporting what was common knowledge about Christians in his time—*i.e.*, what Christians themselves said about their origins.

- **Christian source contamination.** By 116 CE, Christian communities were well established in Rome. Tacitus's information about the origin of the name "Christian" and the circumstances of the founder's death almost certainly derives, directly or indirectly, from Christian tradition. The passage tells us what Christians believed, not what independently verified Roman records contained.

- **Textual questions.** The *Annals* survive in a single manuscript tradition. The earliest manuscript containing Book 15 dates to the eleventh century. While wholesale fabrication of the Tacitus passage is considered unlikely by most scholars, the possibility of

minor interpolation or editorial modification over a millennium of transmission cannot be excluded.

The Tacitus passage confirms that by the early second century a Roman historian—one known for care and hostility toward his subjects—was aware that Christians claimed their founder had been executed under Pilate. It does not provide independent confirmation that this execution occurred, because Tacitus's source is almost certainly the Christian tradition itself. However, the passage is not valueless: it establishes that the historicized narrative (execution under Pilate) was in circulation early enough to reach a Roman historian writing *c.* 116 CE, and that Tacitus saw no reason to question or qualify it. Under the mythicist model, this means the historicization process was substantially complete by the early second century—which is consistent with a timeline in which Mark (*c.* 70 CE) introduced the Palestinian narrative framework, but which places constraints on how late the historicization can be dated.

## 6.4 Pliny, Suetonius, and Other Minor References

Pliny the Younger, writing to the emperor Trajan *c.* 112 CE, describes Christians in Bithynia who sing hymns to "Christus as to a god" (*Epistulae* 10.96). This tells us that Christians worshipped Christ as a deity in the early second century. It tells us nothing about whether the figure they worshipped was historical.

Suetonius, in his *Life of Claudius* (25.4), mentions that Claudius expelled Jews from Rome because of disturbances "at the instigation of Chrestus" (*impulsore Chresto*). The spelling "Chrestus" may refer to Christ or may refer to an otherwise unknown individual named Chrestus—a common slave name. Even on the Christian reading, the passage tells us only that disputes about Christ were causing disturbances in the Roman Jewish community *c.* 49 CE, not that Christ was a historical person.

The Talmudic references to Jesus (primarily in *b. Sanhedrin* 43a and 107b) date from the third to fifth centuries CE and are transparently shaped by polemical engagement with Christian claims rather than by independent historical tradition. Ehrman [2012] himself acknowledges that this material is too late to be of significant historical value.

Mara bar Serapion, a Syrian Stoic writing from prison sometime after 73 CE (the date is disputed; some place the letter much later), refers to the Jews executing "their wise king." The identification with Jesus is not certain—the reference could be to another figure—and even if it refers to Jesus, the information is vague and likely derived from Christian tradition rather than independent knowledge.

In sum, the non-Christian attestation for Jesus consists of: one partially or wholly interpolated passage in Josephus; one brief identifying tag in Josephus whose authenticity is debated but which the majority of scholars accept; one reference in Tacitus almost certainly derived from Christian sources but confirming early circulation of the historicized narrative; and a handful of minor references that tell us about the existence of Christians and their beliefs.

This inventory is weaker than the consensus typically claims, but it is not empty. The non-Christian sources collectively establish that by the late first and early second centuries, the claim that Christianity had a historical founder executed under Pilate was in wide circulation and was accepted even by hostile or neutral observers. Under the historicist model, this confirms a historical core. Under the mythicist model, it confirms that the historicization process was rapid and effective. The non-Christian evidence alone cannot decisively distinguish between these readings, but it does constrain the mythicist timeline and establishes that the historicized tradition was not a late development.

## 6.5 Rabbinic References and *Toledoth Yeshu*

The Talmud and related rabbinic literature contain several passages that mention a figure variously named *Yeshu*, *Yeshu ha-Notzri* ("Yeshu the Nazarene"), or *Yeshu ben Pandera*. These are sometimes invoked as non-Christian attestation of the historical Jesus. The textual and interpretive state of this material is rigorously surveyed by Schäfer [2007] and by Meerson and Schäfer [2014]; the following summarises the principal cases and their evidential weight.

**b.Sanhedrin 43a.** "On the eve of Passover, Yeshu was hanged. For forty days beforehand a herald went out in front of him, crying: 'He is going out to be stoned for practicing magic and leading Israel astray…"' This is the most specific talmudic reference and has sometimes been taken as independent rabbinic memory. Schäfer argues it is a late (post-third-century) Babylonian composition that inverts the Christian passion narrative for polemical effect: stoning rather than crucifixion, the formal due-process characterisation serving as counter-claim against Christian allegations of an unjust execution. The passage assumes knowledge of the Christian narrative rather than providing independent corroboration of it.

**b.Sanhedrin 107b and b.Sotah 47a.** Yeshu is described as a disciple of Rabbi Joshua ben Perachiah who was excommunicated for apostasy and idolatry. The chronological anachronism is large (Joshua ben Perachiah lived in the early first century BCE, not the first century CE); the passage is generally treated as polemical construction, not biographical memory.

**b.Shabbat 104b and b.Sanhedrin 67a.** Yeshu ben Pandera / Yeshu ben Stada: a magician who brought spells from Egypt. The "ben Pandera" tradition reappears in Origen's *Contra Celsum* (c. 248 CE) where Celsus's Jewish informant attributes a similar origin story to Jesus. This is the earliest documented rabbinic-tradition material reaching a Christian writer.

***Toledoth Yeshu.*** The *Toledoth Yeshu* compilations (existing in many manuscript recensions; the earliest evidence for oral traditions is patristic, with Agobard of Lyon c. 830 describing the general form) present an extended anti- Christian counter-narrative: Yeshu as illegitimate son of Miriam and a Roman soldier named Pandera or Pantera, trained as a magician, performing miracles by magical means, executed, and buried in a disgraceful grave. Meerson and Schäfer [2014] provide the critical edition and argue that these compilations consolidate oral polemical traditions of varying ages, but that the tradition as a whole originates as *polemical response to the Christian gospel narrative*, not as independent memory of a historical figure.

**Evidential assessment.** None of the rabbinic passages provides early, independent, non-polemical attestation of a first-century Galilean preacher. All of them either post-date the Christian narrative by centuries or are most plausibly understood as polemical engagement with it. Their evidential value for historicity is therefore similar to Tacitus's: they confirm that Christian claims about a historical founder were circulating early enough to attract Jewish polemical response by the late second or early third century, and they inherit the historicizing frame of the Christian tradition without providing independent witness to its content. They do not establish historicity, and they do not disconfirm it either; like the Josephan and Tacitean material, they constrain both hypotheses to accommodate the early circulation of a historicized narrative without favouring either side of the existence question.

A note on *Toledoth Yeshu*'s significance for the paper's argument. The *Toledoth Yeshu* material has been read by some mythicist-sympathetic writers as evidence that the earliest Jewish engagement with the Christian claim treated it as a fabrication rather than as a memory of a known figure. This reading is over-stated: polemical counter-narratives routinely invert the claims they oppose without thereby taking a position on the existence of the underlying subject, and the ben Pandera tradition assumes enough of the Christian figure to count as engagement rather than denial. What the tradition does establish is that the rabbinic community's earliest substantial response to Christianity was polemical reshaping of the Gospel narrative, not independent testimony to events.

## 6.6 The Mandaean Tradition

The Mandaeans are a surviving religious community of Southern Mesopotamian origin with demonstrably pre-modern roots and a substantial textual tradition in Eastern Aramaic (Mandaic). They are centred on John the Baptist (Mandaic *Yahya* or *Yuhana*) rather than on Jesus, and their canonical literature contains independent references to Jesus that are almost entirely ignored in the historical-Jesus scholarly literature. Rudolph [1978], Lupieri [2002], and Buckley [2002] give the standard recent surveys.

**The community and its sources.** The Mandaean canonical texts include:

- the **Ginza Rabba** ("Great Treasure"), a compendium of mythological, theological, liturgical, and historical material;
- the **Drasha d-Yahya** ("Teaching of John", or "Book of John");
- the **Qolasta** (the canonical prayerbook);
- the **Haran Gawaita**, a short historical-mythological text that narrates the community's migration from Palestine/Judea to Mesopotamia under persecution.

Dating is the central problem. The manuscripts we possess are late medieval; the texts themselves are generally agreed to contain layered traditions of varying ages, with some scholars (Lidzbarski 1925, Buckley 2002) arguing for first- or second-century origins for portions of the material, and others (Lupieri 2002) for a later Mesopotamian composition with earlier traditions embedded. The *Haran Gawaita*'s self-report of a first-century CE westward origin is contested but is not in itself implausible.

**Mandaean references to Jesus.** Mandaean texts refer to Jesus as *Yišu Mshiha* and treat him as a *false* messiah—a corrupter of John the Baptist's teaching, associated with the evil spirit *Rûha* and at times with the planet Mercury in Mandaean astrological symbolism. The principal passages are scattered through the Ginza Rabba (especially Book 1, Right Ginza) and the Book of John. The Jesus figure is given narrative detail: his baptism by John (accepted by the Mandaean tradition but with reversed valuation, Jesus as the one baptized who then corrupts the lineage), his claim to messiahship, and his execution. He is treated as a specific historical figure whose existence is not denied but whose significance is inverted.

**Evidential assessment.** The Mandaean tradition is potentially the most interesting unexploited witness for the historicity question, but the evidential gain is limited by what the tradition actually preserves and by the dating problem. Three considerations apply.

*First, the Mandaean Jesus is not a biographically detailed figure.* The references assume a Jesus whose existence is the framework for polemical reversal of Christian claims, but they do not preserve biographical content that is independent of the Christian narrative itself. Like the rabbinic material in §6.5, the Mandaean Jesus appears to be known through polemical engagement with the Christian tradition rather than through independent memory of a first-century figure.

*Second, the dating problem is severe.* The Mandaean texts in their current form post-date Christianity by centuries; even the most generous reconstructions of the earlier oral traditions cannot rule out that the Mandaean Jesus-material originated as response to Christian claims circulating in Mesopotamia by the third or fourth century.

*Third, and crucially, the Mandaean community's existence is itself a datum.* If (as the *Haran Gawaita* claims and as some scholarship supports) the Mandaeans derive from a first-century Palestinian John-the-Baptist-aligned sectarian community that moved east under Christian and Roman pressure, then the Mandaean tradition represents a living continuation of the Second Temple Jewish apocalyptic-mystical milieu in which earliest Christianity formed. Whether the Mandaean Jesus is independent memory or later polemical construction, the Mandaean existence is evidence for the diversity of the religious milieu from which Christianity differentiated—and that diversity constrains any theory of the earliest Christian community's emergence.

**Honest status.** The Mandaean material *does not provide* independent first-century attestation of a historical Jesus; the tradition is too late and too dependent on the Christian narrative to carry that weight. It *does not refute* historicity either. What it offers is a live pre-Islamic (and perhaps pre-Christian-in-origin) religious tradition that knew Jesus as a contested polemical figure rather than as the centre of its own theology. A more thorough engagement with the Mandaean material—specifically, an analysis of whether any Mandaean Jesus-references can be textually dated to pre-Constantinian Mesopotamian material—would constitute genuinely novel evidence for either side of the debate. The field has not done this work; we note the opportunity without claiming to have done it here.

## 6.7 Archaeological Substrate: Nazareth, Sepphoris, and the Yehohanan Ossuary

Archaeology occasionally settles historicity questions decisively: the 1961 Pilate inscription at Caesarea Maritima [Vardaman, 1962] moved Pilate from literary-only attestation to physical attestation. For Jesus, no comparable artefact exists. Four archaeological considerations nonetheless bear on the question.

**The habitation of first-century Nazareth.** Salm [2008] argued a skeptical case that Nazareth was uninhabited in the first century CE, making the village setting of the Gospel nativity and youth narratives a literary fiction. His argument rested on the alleged absence of datable first-century remains in early Israeli excavations. Reed [2000], Dark [2020], and specialist archaeologists (notably James Strange and Stephen Pfann) have responded in detail, arguing that first-century CE habitation is attested by pottery, rock-cut tombs (e.g., Kokhim tombs of Jewish type), agricultural installations (wine and olive presses), and some structural remains recently re-examined by the Nazareth Archaeological Project. The mainstream archaeological consensus now is that Nazareth was a small Jewish village through the first century, though with a very modest footprint. Salm's case has been effectively answered in the specialist literature.

The implication for historicity is modest. A village Nazareth's existence does not confirm Jesus. A non-existent Nazareth would have been a substantial argument against the Gospel narratives, and that argument is not available. The Gospel-era Nazareth was a small, obscure village—which is neither surprising nor informative on the principal question.

**The silence about Sepphoris.** Sepphoris was a major Hellenistic-Jewish urban centre approximately four miles (six kilometres) from Nazareth, serving as the administrative capital of Galilee under Herod Antipas. By any plausible reconstruction of a Nazareth-based Galilean ministry, a public-teaching figure would have had to engage with Sepphoris or deliberately to avoid it. *Sepphoris is conspicuously absent from every Gospel text.* This is a minor datum but worth registering: the Gospel narratives construct their Galilean setting around small villages (Nazareth, Capernaum, Cana, Bethsaida) and never mention the regional administrative capital. If the Gospel writers were reconstructing a historical ministry from memory, this absence is puzzling; if they were constructing a narrative from scriptural Galilean imagery (fishermen, villages, boats, grain fields) without specific historical constraint, the absence is expected. Sepphoris is not a decisive datum, but it is a consilience pointing in the paper's direction.

**The Yehohanan ossuary and the archaeology of crucifixion.** Tzaferis [1970] and Zias and Sekeles [1985] published and reappraised the bone remains of Yehohanan ben Hagkol, a first- century CE crucifixion victim whose heel bone was discovered in 1968 with a Roman iron nail still in place. This is the *only* surviving archaeological evidence of Roman crucifixion in Judea. Its relevance to historicity is this: crucifixion was a real Roman practice in first-century Palestine—we have physical evidence—but the practice left almost no archaeological trace in general, because bodies were typically disposed of in mass or open pits and because nails of this kind were routinely reused. The absence of an archaeological trace for a specific crucified Jesus is thus of negligible evidential weight either way.

**The James ossuary and forgery-determination.** In 2002 an ossuary inscribed with the Aramaic phrase "James, son of Joseph, brother of Jesus" (*Ya'akov bar Yosef achui d'Yeshua*) became briefly a candidate for the first direct archaeological attestation of Jesus. The subsequent investigation by the Israel Antiquities Authority and ensuing trial (Oded Golan, 2005–2012) concluded that at least the "brother of Jesus" portion of the inscription was a modern forgery added to an otherwise genuine first-century ossuary. The case is legally concluded but the physical and epigraphic analysis remains contested among specialists. The episode is instructive about the field's sensitivity to any prospect of physical attestation—and, negatively, about how thoroughly the true archaeological record has been searched. No genuine artefact mentioning Jesus from the first century has been recovered, and the field's willingness to treat a contested inscription as potentially definitive evidence signals the evidentiary pressure the historicity question is under.

**Summary.** Archaeology provides no direct evidence for Jesus. The surrounding contextual archaeology (first-century Nazareth's existence, Pilate's confirmed prefecture, the physical reality of crucifixion in Judea) is consistent with the Gospel setting but does not confirm a specific figure. The absence of direct physical attestation is not decisive in itself—many first- century Galilean peasants are archaeologically invisible—but it places Jesus on the Socrates/Pythagoras side of the evidential profile rather than the Pilate/Augustus side.

# 7 The Argument from Silence

Section 2.3 established the formal principle that absence of expected evidence is evidence of absence, with strength proportional to how confidently the evidence would be expected under the hypothesis. This section applies that principle to specific documentary traditions that should contain references to Jesus if the historicist hypothesis is correct.

## 7.1 Philo of Alexandria

Philo Judaeus (*c.* 20 BCE–*c.* 50 CE) was a Hellenistic Jewish philosopher who wrote extensively on Jewish theology, law, philosophy, and politics. His surviving corpus is enormous—over forty treatises. He was an exact contemporary of the supposed Jesus and lived in Alexandria, a major center of Jewish intellectual life closely connected to Jerusalem.

Philo's writings are directly relevant to the historicity question on multiple fronts:

- He discusses Pontius Pilate at length, describing his administration and its conflicts with the Jewish population (*Legatio ad Gaium* 299–305).
- He writes extensively about Jewish messianic expectation, about the interpretation of Hebrew Bible prophecy, about Wisdom and Logos theology—precisely the intellectual milieu from which Christianity emerged.
- He describes Jewish sectarian movements, including the Essenes and the Therapeutae.
- He lived during the period when Jesus supposedly taught, attracted followers, was executed, and his movement began spreading across the Mediterranean.

Philo never mentions Jesus, Christians, or anything recognizable as the Christian movement.

The historicist response is that Jesus was too obscure to attract Philo's notice. This defense has more force than mythicists typically acknowledge. Philo lived in Alexandria, not Jerusalem. He was a philosopher, not a chronicler of Galilean preachers. His writings are thematically focused on scriptural interpretation, Jewish law, and relations with Roman authority—topics that would not necessarily lead him to discuss an itinerant teacher in a distant province. If the historical Jesus was a minor figure—a local teacher with a small following, executed as one of many would-be messiahs—Philo's silence is unremarkable.

However, this defense has limits. If a significant religious movement emerged from within Palestinian Judaism during Philo's lifetime—a movement making extraordinary claims about a recently-executed Messiah—and if this movement was sufficiently organized to produce communities across the Mediterranean within two decades (as Paul's letters attest), then its complete absence from the most prolific Jewish writer of the period is at least noteworthy. The strength of this silence as evidence depends on how visible the early Christian movement was: if it was a tiny, obscure sect (as historicists who invoke the "obscurity" defense must maintain), Philo's silence is unsurprising; but this smallness claim is in tension with the Gospel narratives describing large crowds and public confrontation.

Under the historicist hypothesis, $P(\text{Philo silent} \mid H)$ is difficult to estimate—it depends on how prominent Jesus and his movement actually were, which is precisely what is in dispute. The silence of Philo is suggestive but weaker than a maximalist mythicist reading would claim.

## 7.2 Justus of Tiberias

Justus of Tiberias was a Jewish historian and contemporary of Josephus who wrote a history of the Jewish war and, importantly, a chronicle of events in Galilee—the region where Jesus supposedly conducted his ministry. His works are lost, but the ninth-century patriarch Photius read them and recorded his reaction in his *Bibliotheca* (Codex 33):

> [Justus] makes not the least mention of the appearance of Christ, or what things happened to him, or of the wonderful works that he did.

Photius, a Christian reader, found this silence remarkable. And well he might: a historian of Galilee, writing about the very region and period of Jesus's supposed activity, who makes no mention of Jesus or his followers.

The historicist defense is that Justus's work is lost and we cannot know its full contents from Photius's brief notice. This is true but irrelevant: Photius specifically comments on the absence of any mention of Christ, indicating that he searched for one and did not find it. Given that Photius was a Christian patriarch with every motivation to find such a reference, his explicit notice of its absence carries significant weight.

## 7.3 The Mishnaic Tradition

The Mishnah, compiled *c.* 200 CE from earlier oral traditions, contains extensive discussions of Sanhedrin procedure, heresy trials, capital punishment, the authority of the high priest, and the relationship between Jewish and Roman legal jurisdiction—precisely the institutional context in which Jesus supposedly appeared, was tried, and was condemned.

The Mishnah contains no recognizable reference to the trial or execution of Jesus. However, the evidential weight of this silence must be carefully calibrated. The Mishnah is a legal code, not a chronicle of historical events. It records legal principles and procedural norms, not specific cases. It contains no reference to the trial of Hillel, or to any specific execution outside its legal hypotheticals. The absence of Jesus's trial from the Mishnah is therefore less surprising than it might initially appear—the Mishnah omits most specific historical events.

That said, if the Gospel trial narrative is historical, it describes proceedings that egregiously violated Mishnaic procedural norms (a night trial, a capital case decided in a single

day, a trial during a festival). The Mishnah's framers might have had reason to address such a case precisely because of its procedural irregularity. The silence is mildly suggestive but not strong evidence on its own.

The later Talmudic references (discussed in Section 6.4) are too late and too obviously polemical to represent independent tradition. They respond to Christian claims rather than preserving pre-Christian memory.

## 7.4 Roman Administrative Records

The Roman Empire maintained administrative records of provincial governance, including judicial proceedings. While the vast majority of such records have been lost, the complete absence of any reference to a trial or execution of Jesus in any surviving Roman document, inscription, or administrative text is notable—particularly because we do possess Roman references to other events in Judean governance from the same period.

The Pilate inscription from Caesarea Maritima confirms Pilate's historicity and his title (*praefectus*). We have coins minted under Pilate's authority. We have Philo's and Josephus's independent accounts of Pilate's administration. The Roman apparatus in Judea left traces. The trial and execution of Jesus did not—unless one counts the Tacitus passage, which, as argued above, derives from Christian tradition rather than Roman records.

The force of this silence depends on how many records we would expect to survive. Individual provincial trials were unlikely to be preserved in the historical record on their own. But the Gospel accounts do not describe an ordinary trial. They describe a case involving the Roman prefect personally, a Sanhedrin convened for the purpose, crowds demanding execution, extraordinary portents (earthquake, darkness, temple veil rent), and an executed man's body going missing. If even a fraction of this occurred, the event was extraordinary, and extraordinary events leave traces.

## 7.5 Cumulative Force of Absent Evidence

No single silence is decisive. The force of the argument lies in its cumulative structure.

The following documentary channels would plausibly contain a reference to Jesus if the historicist hypothesis is true. They are listed in approximate order of expected sensitivity—*i.e.*, the probability that each would mention Jesus given historicity—from strongest to weakest:

1. **Justus of Tiberias** (late first century): a historian of Galilee—Jesus's supposed home region—who made no mention of Christ, as the ninth-century patriarch Photius explic-

itly noted. This is among the strongest individual silences, though it depends on a single late witness to a lost work.

2. **Philo of Alexandria** (*c.* 20 BCE–50 CE): the most prolific Jewish writer of the period, who discussed Pilate, messianic expectation, and Jewish sectarian movements. No mention. The force of this silence is moderated by Philo's location (Alexandria, not Jerusalem) and his philosophical rather than chronicling orientation (Section 7.1).

3. **Roman administrative records from Judea**: no surviving reference to a trial or execution of Jesus, despite the survival of other traces of Pilate's administration. The force is moderated by the general loss of provincial records from this period.

4. **Seneca the Younger** (*c.* 4 BCE–65 CE): Stoic philosopher and tutor to Nero, who wrote on Jewish topics. No mention.

5. **The Mishnaic legal tradition**: compiled *c.* 200 CE from earlier oral traditions. No reference to a trial of Jesus. The force is weak: the Mishnah is a legal code, not a chronicle, and its silence is not surprising given its genre (Section 7.3).

6. **The Dead Sea Scrolls community at Qumran**: deeply engaged with messianic expectation and Jewish sectarianism. No mention. The force is weak: the community's literary activity largely predates the period of Jesus's supposed activity.

The cumulative argument is strongest when limited to the first three channels—sources that would plausibly mention a messianic figure executed by the Roman prefect in their region and period—and weakest for genre-inappropriate sources (the Mishnah) or chronologically marginal ones (the Dead Sea Scrolls). The argument does not depend on any single weak channel.

The qualitative conclusion is defensible: the pattern of silence across multiple traditions is *more consistent with* the mythic-origin model than with the historicist model, because the mythic-origin model predicts silence while the historicist model must explain it through auxiliary hypotheses about obscurity. The cumulative weight of the silence is real but difficult to quantify precisely. It is one strand of a cumulative case, not a standalone proof.

The argument from silence, properly formulated, is not a gap in the evidence. It is evidence. Its cumulative weight favors the mythic-origin hypothesis—but with less certainty than a maximalist mythicist reading would claim.

# 8 Prior Sources: The Jewish-Apocalyptic Matrix

A central claim of this paper is that every narrative element of the Jesus tradition can be traced to identifiable prior sources. An older popularization of this claim (associated with Frazer [1890]) located those sources primarily in pagan Mediterranean mystery religions—the cults of Osiris, Attis, Adonis, Dionysus—and is what most readers probably think of when they encounter the phrase "mythicist hypothesis." That framing is the weakest version of the argument and is not the one defended here. As Fredriksen [2017, 2018] rightly insists, Paul is a Second Temple Jewish apocalyptic thinker operating within Jewish categories, not a syncretist blending in pagan myth. The Gospel authors, however they stood with respect to Jewish practice, are demonstrably citing Jewish scripture as their primary source of narrative material. The honest argument is therefore not that Christianity copied dying-and-rising mystery cults but that the Jesus tradition is constructed from the scriptural, apocalyptic, and mystical resources of Second Temple Judaism itself, with Hellenistic literary conventions providing ambient narrative shaping secondary to that primary Jewish matrix.

This section develops that argument. Section 8.1 establishes the Jewish-apocalyptic matrix: pre-existent heavenly mediators, angelomorphic Christology, Philo's *Logos*, the Danielic Son of Man, and the Suffering Servant. Section 8.3 catalogs the specific Hebrew Bible templates from which Gospel narrative episodes are constructed. Section 8.4 addresses the strongest specific challenge to the mythic-origin reading of Paul—the Davidic-descent claim in Romans 1:3—and engages Novenson [2017] on Second Temple messianic grammar. Section 8.5 locates the secondary Hellenistic resonances in their proper, supporting role. Section 8.6 addresses the "nobody would invent a crucified Messiah" argument.

## 8.1 The Jewish-Apocalyptic Matrix as Primary Source

The decisive observation of recent scholarship, from Fredriksen [2017] through Boyarin [2012] and in the explicit argumentative architecture of Carrier [2014], is that the theological building-blocks of earliest Christian Christology are already present in pre-Christian Second Temple Judaism. Paul does not reach outside his Jewish tradition for the raw materials of his soteriology; he reaches deeper into it.

**Pre-existent heavenly mediators.** The idea of a divine or quasi-divine figure who exists alongside God, functions as God's agent in creation and providence, and mediates between the transcendent deity and human beings is extensively attested in pre-Christian Jewish sources. Boyarin [2012] traces this "binitarian" strand through the Danielic Son of Man

(Daniel 7:13–14), the *Similitudes of Enoch* (1 Enoch 37–71), the Melchizedek traditions at Qumran (11QMelch), the angel Metatron in the Hekhalot tradition, and the Logos of Philo of Alexandria. Paul's Christ is not an exotic Hellenistic import into Judaism; he is a recognizable member of the Jewish pre-existent-mediator family. The Philippians 2:5–11 hymn—"in the form of God. . . emptied himself. . . taking the form of a servant. . . therefore God highly exalted him"—describes a descent-and-exaltation arc that maps onto the Second Temple pattern of angelomorphic humiliation and vindication (compare the Self-Glorification Hymn at Qumran, 4Q491c), not onto the death-and-rebirth cycle of Attis.

**Philo's Logos.** Sterling [2001] and the broader Philo commentary tradition document Philo's Logos theology in detail. The Logos is pre-existent, is God's agent in creation, is called "son of God" and "firstborn", is the mediator through whom humans approach God, and is sometimes described as "a second god" (*deuteros theos*, *Questions on Genesis* 2.62). Philo wrote in Alexandria in the same decades as Paul's formation. The conceptual inventory from which early Christological language was assembled was already Jewish-Hellenistic and available; no pagan borrowing is required.

**The Danielic Son of Man and the apocalyptic messiah.** Daniel 7:13–14—"one like a son of man came with the clouds of heaven. . . and to him was given dominion and glory and kingdom"— became a central messianic text in Second Temple apocalypticism. The *Similitudes of Enoch* (1 Enoch 37–71), dateable on current best estimates to the late first century BCE or early first century CE, identifies this Son of Man as a pre-existent, named, and hidden heavenly figure who will appear at the end of days to execute judgment. This is not Christian material; it is the Jewish matrix from which Christian material was drawn.

**The Suffering Servant and vicarious death.** Isaiah 52:13–53:12 describes a righteous figure who suffers vicariously ("he was pierced for our transgressions, crushed for our iniquities"), is "cut off from the land of the living," and is afterward vindicated. Whether this passage was read messianically in pre-Christian Judaism is contested, but the *raw material* for a theology of a righteous sufferer whose death atones for others is already present in the Jewish canon. Nickelsburg [1972] showed that Wisdom of Solomon 2–5 had independently developed a similar pattern of persecuted-righteous-one vindication.

**The significance of the matrix for mythic-origin scenarios.** The mythic-origin scenario does not require recourse to dying-and- rising mystery cults. Every element Paul claims about Christ—pre- existence, descent, vicarious suffering, resurrection, exaltation,

cosmic lordship—is derivable from Jewish scriptural and apocalyptic sources available in the first century. This is also *a fortiori* the safer argument, since the Jewish sources are textually secure (the Qumran material was effectively sealed by 70 CE and shows no Christian influence) while the pagan parallels face genuine scholarly contestation as to dating, comparability, and direction of influence.

## 8.2 The Revelatory Mechanism: Jewish Mystical Ascent and Pauline *Apokalypsis*

The mythic-origin scenario claims that Paul's Christ was known to the earliest community through scriptural exegesis and revelation rather than through historical memory. This claim is commonly dismissed as methodologically convenient—"revelation can explain anything"—but the dismissal is not warranted. Second Temple Judaism possessed a specific, well-attested set of *procedures* for generating religious knowledge about heavenly realities. These procedures have been documented in detail by specialists on Jewish mysticism and apocalypticism, though the literature has been surprisingly little engaged by historical-Jesus scholars on either side.

**Paul's own testimony on method.** Paul explicitly and repeatedly tells us that his Christ-knowledge was generated by two channels, revelation and scripture: "I did not receive [the gospel] from any human source nor was I taught it, but I received it through a revelation of Jesus Christ" (*di' apokalypseōs Iēsou Christou*, Galatians 1:12). "When God... was pleased to reveal his Son in me (*apokalypsai ton huion autou en emoi*), so that I might proclaim him among the Gentiles" (Galatians 1:15–16). "I went up in response to a revelation" (*kata apokalypsin*, Galatians 2:2). Paul places himself among "those who were apostles before me" (Galatians 1:17), and the context throughout Galatians 1–2 frames his knowledge as received directly rather than mediated through a recently-living figure.

Paul also cites scripture as the source of his most compressed Christological statements. "Christ died for our sins *in accordance with the scriptures*... and was raised on the third day *in accordance with the scriptures*" (1 Corinthians 15:3–4). The formula is apparently pre-Pauline; its grammar is exegetical; scripture is explicitly the warranting source of the content.

The combination of *apokalypsis* with scriptural exegesis is not an ad hoc pairing. It is the attested epistemology of Second Temple Jewish apocalyptic-mystical writing generally.

**The Jewish mystical-ascent tradition.** Pre-Christian and early-Christian-era Jewish literature documents a specific set of practices and texts in which visionary ascent through the heavens and exegetical decoding of scripture together generate knowledge of heavenly realities that the community then articulates and transmits. The foundational modern study is Scholem [1941], supplemented by Gruenwald [1980], Rowland [1982], Schäfer [2009], and Elior [2004].

Representative texts and traditions:

- **1 Enoch** (portions pre-second-century BCE through first century CE), especially the *Similitudes* (1 Enoch 37–71): Enoch is taken up to heaven, shown cosmic secrets, and identifies a named, hidden, pre-existent Son of Man who will execute eschatological judgment. This is not Christian material; it is the Jewish matrix.

- **The Apocalypse of Abraham** (first or second century CE): Abraham undergoes angelic ascent, receives visions of the cosmic order, and learns the identity of heavenly mediators.

- **The Ascension of Isaiah** (first or early second century; discussed in Section 5.4): Isaiah ascends through the seven heavens, sees the pre-existent Beloved, and witnesses the Beloved's descent, crucifixion (in the sublunar realm, in some readings), and return. The text is formally a mystical-ascent apocalypse, and some readers [Carrier, 2014] argue it preserves an earlier form of the Christian revelation prior to its historicization.

- **The Dead Sea Scrolls Self-Glorification Hymn** (4Q491c, 4Q427): an otherwise-unnamed speaker claims to have ascended to heaven, to sit enthroned among the angelic council, and to have received divine knowledge. The speaker's identity is contested, but the *procedure*—first-person mystical ascent to the heavenly court, receiving knowledge and authority— is exactly the procedure Paul describes for himself (2 Corinthians 12:2–4: "I know a person in Christ who fourteen years ago was caught up to the third heaven. . . caught up into Paradise and heard things that are not to be told").

- **The Merkabah and Hekhalot literature** (traditionally dated late but with first-century-CE roots according to Schäfer 2009 and Elior 2004): detailed instructions and narratives for mystical ascent to the *merkabah* (divine chariot-throne of Ezekiel 1), culminating in vision of the seated figure on the throne and reception of heavenly knowledge.

- **Philo's own reports**: Philo describes ecstatic experiences and visionary reception of philosophical-theological truth (*On the Creation* 71; *Special Laws* 3.1–6; *On the Cheru-*

*bim* 27), and his interpretive method for scripture is allegorical decoding of a text understood as encoding heavenly mysteries.

The common structure across these texts is: a visionary ascends (or is taken up by an angelic guide) through celestial realms, receives visions of heavenly figures and cosmic secrets, and is commissioned to communicate those realities. The resulting literature is explicitly generated by these means. Nothing in the procedure requires or implies recent historical events; the content of the vision is new knowledge, not recalled memory.

**Paul's profile fits this matrix exactly.** Segal [1990] argued in detail that Paul's self-description matches the profile of a Jewish mystical visionary: he reports direct *apokalypsis* of a heavenly Christ-figure (Galatians 1:12–16), describes himself being caught up to the third heaven where he hears unutterable things (2 Corinthians 12:2–4), claims his knowledge was not mediated by human testimony (Galatians 1:11–17), and frames his apostolic authority as derivative from direct heavenly commissioning rather than from discipleship to a teacher. Smith [1978] argued further that the earliest Jesus tradition itself bears the marks of a mystical-ecstatic operational mode—an argument that has been controversial but that remains serious in the scholarly literature. Rowland [1982] situates Paul's self-presentation within the mainstream Jewish apocalyptic-visionary tradition rather than as an isolated or exotic phenomenon.

**What this implies for historicity.** The implication is not that Paul was lying or that his community fabricated its claims. It is that the *epistemic mechanism* by which Paul and his community came to know about their Christ is the same epistemic mechanism by which the authors of 1 Enoch's *Similitudes*, the Self-Glorification Hymn, the Apocalypse of Abraham, the Ascension of Isaiah, and the Merkabah literature came to know about their heavenly figures. None of those figures required a recent historical instantiation for the revelatory knowledge to be generated. The earliest Christian community could have come to know its Christ by the same route, and Paul *tells us* that that is how he came to know him.

The historicist response to this observation must be that Paul's language about revelation is a theological gloss on what was in fact community memory of a historical figure. This is possible but requires that Paul, who emphatically insists his knowledge came *not from human sources* (Galatians 1:11–12, 1:16–17), was either lying, mistaken, or using technical theological language in a sense he did not mean. None of these is the most parsimonious reading of the text. The parsimonious reading is that Paul means what he says about his epistemic source, that his procedure is the well-attested Jewish mystical-apocalyptic procedure, and that the content of his revelation is the same kind of content (a heavenly mediator

figure with cosmic soteriological functions) that the comparable texts in his tradition also produce.

This does not prove that the Christ Paul revealed had no historical instantiation. It does establish that *no historical instantiation is required* for the evidentiary trail Paul leaves to exist. The historicity of Jesus is, in this framing, not a necessary postulate to explain Paul's letters; it is a separate question requiring independent evidence.

## 8.3 Hebrew Bible Typology: The Specific Templates

The Jewish scriptural sources for the Jesus narrative have been discussed in Section 4.5 in connection with the passion narrative. Here the point is generalized: the Jesus tradition is constructed from Hebrew Bible typology not only in its death narrative but across its entire arc.

The birth narratives draw on the births of Moses (Pharaoh's massacre / Herod's massacre), Samuel (miraculous conception, dedication to God's service), and Isaac (divine promise, elderly or virginal conception). The ministry recapitulates Elijah-Elisha (Section 4.1). The entry into Jerusalem fulfills Zechariah 9:9. The Last Supper draws on Passover typology. The crucifixion is built from Psalm 22 and Isaiah 53. The resurrection draws on Hosea 6:2 ("after two days he will revive us; on the third day he will raise us up"), Jonah 1:17 (three days in the belly of the fish, explicitly cited in Matthew 12:40), and the general pattern of divine vindication found throughout the Psalms and prophetic literature.

The ascension draws on Elijah's ascent to heaven in a chariot of fire (2 Kings 2:11) and Daniel's Son of Man ascending to the Ancient of Days (Daniel 7:13–14). The promise of return draws on Daniel 7, Zechariah 14, and the general eschatological framework of late Second Temple Judaism.

When every major episode in the Jesus narrative can be derived from a specific scriptural source, the hypothesis that historical events *preceded* the scriptural interpretation becomes less parsimonious than the hypothesis that scriptural sources *generated* the narrative. The tradition reads as a systematic program of scriptural fulfillment—which is exactly how the Gospel authors present it (Matthew's formula citations: "this took place to fulfill what had been spoken through the prophet. . . "). The question is whether the authors were recognizing fulfillment in historical events or constructing narrative to demonstrate fulfillment. The evidence, as analyzed throughout this paper, favors the latter.

## 8.4 Davidic Messianism and Romans 1:3

The single most difficult Pauline passage for the mythic-origin scenario is Romans 1:3: Christ "came into being from the seed of David according to the flesh" (*tou genomenou ek spermatos Dauid kata sarka*). Davidic descent is a genealogical claim. Novenson [2012, 2017] has documented systematically that "messiah" language in Second Temple Judaism operates within specific grammatical constraints: a messiah is a human figure, a descendant of a specific royal line, anointed for specific offices. Messianic language was not available as a detachable cosmic abstraction in Paul's environment. If Rom 1:3 is an authentic Pauline statement about Christ, it anchors the Christ-figure in a specific human genealogical line.

The mythicist response must be honest about the difficulty. The response runs along three lines.

**Interpolation.** Romans 1:3–4 is widely recognized as a pre-Pauline creedal fragment quoted by Paul rather than composed by him (Section 3.1; Jewett 2007). Paul inherits this formula; he does not originate it. The formula belongs to the earliest Christian community, but its phrasing may reflect that community's interpretive commitments rather than Paul's own primary Christological categories. Elsewhere in Paul, Davidic descent never functions argumentatively; it is asserted once, in a formula, and not developed.

**Celestial incarnation into Davidic flesh.** Carrier [2014] argues that *kata sarka* ("according to the flesh") is a technical Pauline phrase that can locate an event in the sublunar realm of flesh without committing to a specific earthly biography. A pre-existent celestial figure who takes on Davidic lineage in the moment of descent into flesh is a coherent (if counterintuitive) reading of the Jewish angelomorphic material catalogued above. This reading is not the most natural reading of Rom 1:3 in isolation; it is the reading that harmonizes Rom 1:3 with the broader pattern of Paul's discourse.

**The remaining honest tension.** Neither of these responses fully dissolves the difficulty. Novenson's point is not blunted by the creedal-fragment move: even if the formula is pre-Pauline, Paul has endorsed it by including it in his prefatory greeting to the Romans, and pre-Pauline creeds are evidence of the *earliest* stratum of Christian claim-making. And the celestial-incarnation reading of *kata sarka* in Rom 1:3 is defensible but strained. This paper's conclusion acknowledges the passage as one of the genuine challenges for mythicism. A rigorous mythic-origin scenario must either accept a weakened prior on historicity grounds from Rom 1:3 or propose a defensible interpolation hypothesis for the specific clause *ek spermatos Dauid*. We do not pretend that this has been resolved.

A final observation: the difficulty of Rom 1:3 is shared with the remaining Pauline tensions noted throughout this paper (Gal 4:4, 1 Cor 15:3–8, and some passages in 1 Corinthians). These tensions do not vanish under the mythicist scenario, but they are also not neutral evidence for historicity. They are specifically evidence that Paul's earliest community had already moved—by the time Paul wrote in the 50s—from a purely revelatory celestial Christ to one who had at minimum been woven into a Jewish messianic-genealogical frame. What the evidence cannot distinguish is whether that move reflects memory of a specific historical individual or reflects scriptural exegesis identifying the heavenly mediator as, necessarily, of David's line (Jer 23:5, 33:15; Isa 11:1–10; Ps 89; 2 Sam 7).

## 8.5 Hellenistic Resonances as Secondary Context

A complete account of the ambient literary and religious environment in which the Jesus tradition took shape includes, secondarily, a set of Hellenistic conventions and religious patterns. These are not the primary source of the tradition—the Jewish matrix of Section 8.1 is—but they represent the shared narrative grammar of the Mediterranean world within which the Jesus tradition was articulated, circulated, and received.

**The *theios anēr* biographical template.** Greco-Roman literary culture had a well-established pattern for biographies of divinely-endowed figures (*theios anēr*, "divine man")—miraculous birth, wisdom teaching, miracle-working, conflict with authorities, noble death, and post-mortem appearances or ascent [Bieler, 1935, Tiede, 1972]. Apollonius of Tyana, Pythagoras, and Alexander the Great attracted biographical traditions conforming to this pattern. Philostratus's *Life of Apollonius* (*c.* 220 CE, drawing on earlier material) is the closest extant literary analogue to the Gospels, and the structural parallels are extensive. The Gospel authors were not writing in a cultural vacuum; they were writing in a literary world where biographical narratives of divine-human figures had conventional shapes. The Jesus story conforms to those shapes in every major element. This does not prove the subject was fictional—historical subjects can be described in conventional terms—but it removes any presumption that the narrative's biographical specificity reflects specifically historical (as opposed to conventionally literary) content.

**The dying-and-rising-god pattern (carefully qualified).** A generation of mythicist writing prominently argued, following Frazer [1890], that Christianity drew centrally on a Mediterranean pattern of deities who die and return to life: Osiris, Attis, Adonis, Dionysus, Tammuz/Dumuzi. This argument has been heavily criticized. Smith [2005], in the

most widely cited recent critique, argued that the "dying-and-rising god" category was substantially a construction of nineteenth- and twentieth-century scholarship that over-read the sources. Mettinger [2001] subsequently defended a more limited version of the category—genuine pre-Christian dying-and-rising deities in Mesopotamian (Dumuzi), Ugaritic (Baal), and Phoenician (Melqart) sources, with the Adonis case probably genuine—while agreeing that the older, broader Frazerian generalization was indefensible.

The present paper takes the cautious position that some limited Mediterranean dying-and-rising tradition is real but is *not* the primary source of Pauline or Gospel material. Paul's actual Christology, as developed in Section 8.1, is assembled from Jewish apocalyptic-mystical resources. The Hellenistic dying-and-rising pattern may have made Paul's gospel culturally intelligible to gentile audiences (this is a plausible reading of 1 Cor 1:23, "Christ crucified... foolishness to the Gentiles"), but it does not supply the generative theological machinery. Historicist authors who treat "parallels with Attis and Osiris" as the central mythicist claim are attacking a weaker version of the argument than the one this paper defends. Fredriksen [2017] is correct that Paul is not a syncretist drawing on pagan cult; the mythicist case does not require that he was.

## 8.6 The "Nobody Would Invent a Crucified Messiah" Argument

The argument from the "scandal" of the cross is perhaps the most influential single argument for historicity. It runs as follows: Jewish messianic expectation anticipated a triumphant royal or priestly figure, not a crucified criminal. Crucifixion was the most shameful form of Roman execution. No one within a Jewish context would invent a Messiah who was crucified; therefore, the crucifixion must be historical, and the early Christian claim that the crucified Jesus was the Messiah must have arisen from the need to make sense of an actual event [Hengel, 1977, Wright, 1996].

This argument has been treated as nearly decisive for decades. It has serious problems.

First, it assumes complete knowledge of Second Temple Jewish sectarian thought. The Dead Sea Scrolls, discovered beginning in 1947, revealed entire theological traditions previously unknown to scholarship. The claim that "no Jew would expect a dying Messiah" is an argument from ignorance of a tradition that was far more diverse than our evidence allows us to map exhaustively.

Second, the argument ignores the Suffering Servant tradition of Isaiah 52:13–53:12, which was available in the Jewish canon and describes a righteous figure who suffers vicariously, is despised and rejected, is "cut off from the land of the living," and is afterward vindicated by God. Whether or not this passage was interpreted messianically in pre-Christian Judaism

(a debated question), it provided the raw material for a theology of vicarious suffering and vindication that could be applied to a messianic figure by anyone doing creative scriptural exegesis—which is precisely what the earliest Christians demonstrably did.

Third, the argument assumes an exclusively Jewish audience and an exclusively Jewish frame of reference. But Paul—our earliest source—is writing to mixed communities across the Mediterranean world, communities in which dying-and-rising gods were familiar and religiously compelling. In this broader context, a dying and rising savior was recognizable. However, the historicist has a genuine counter-point here: crucifixion *specifically*—as distinct from divine death generally—carried a particular Roman stigma of degradation and criminality that voluntary divine death (Osiris, Attis) or heroic dismemberment (Dionysus) did not. Paul's own statement that the crucified Christ is "a stumbling block to Jews and foolishness to Gentiles" (1 Corinthians 1:23) plausibly reflects real audience resistance, not merely rhetorical preemption. The mythicist must explain why the tradition chose crucifixion specifically rather than some other form of death.

The strongest mythicist answer centers on Deuteronomy 21:23: "anyone hung on a tree is under God's curse." Paul explicitly cites this passage in Galatians 3:13: "Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us—for it is written, 'Cursed is everyone who hangs on a tree.'" This is not an afterthought; it is the *engine* of Paul's soteriology. The entire logic of vicarious atonement depends on the savior bearing a curse on behalf of others. For this theology to work, the mode of death must be one that is *scripturally cursed*. Stoning, burning, beheading—none of these carry the specific scriptural curse that hanging on a tree does. Crucifixion was not chosen despite being embarrassing; it was chosen *because* it was the one mode of death that could be scripturally identified as "cursed by God," making it the necessary vehicle for a theology of substitutionary curse-bearing. On this reading, the "scandal" of the cross is not evidence of historicity but evidence of theological engineering: the tradition selected the mode of death that generated the maximum soteriological power from available scriptural resources.

Additionally, crucifixion was the most visible, public, and humiliating form of Roman execution—designed not merely to kill but to display power and inflict shame. A savior who died in obscurity would lack the dramatic force that the tradition required. The extremity of the degradation is theologically generative: it maximizes the paradox of divine humiliation and exaltation that structures the Christ hymn in Philippians 2:5–11 ("he humbled himself and became obedient to the point of death—even death on a cross"), where "even death on a cross" functions as a climactic intensifier, not as a reluctant historical admission.

Fourth, the argument has a hidden premise: that embarrassment implies historicity. This is not generally true. Mythological traditions routinely include elements that are "embar-

rassing" by the standards of some audiences while being powerful and attractive to others. The death of Osiris is violent and degrading; the self-castration of Attis is shocking; the dismemberment of Dionysus is grotesque. These elements were not historical concessions; they were mythologically generative. The "scandal" of the cross may function identically: a narratively powerful element that creates theological meaning precisely through its extremity. The parallel is imperfect—crucifixion was a specific, contemporary, politically charged mode of execution—but the principle holds: transgressive and shocking elements in mythological traditions do not require historical events to explain their presence.

The "nobody would invent a crucified Messiah" argument is weaker than the consensus maintains. The Deuteronomy 21:23 argument provides a specific, text-grounded reason why crucifixion was selected, and it is Paul himself who makes the connection explicit. However, the argument retains some force: the specificity of crucifixion as a Roman punishment, with its particular political associations, is not fully explained by the scriptural-curse theory alone. This is a point of genuine tension rather than a decisive victory for either side.

# 9 Source Trajectory: From Mythic to Historical

## 9.1 The Direction of Development

A fundamental prediction distinguishes the two hypotheses. If a historical Jesus existed and was subsequently mythologized, we would expect the earliest sources to be the most historically grounded and the latest sources to show increasing mythological embellishment. If a mythic figure was subsequently historicized, we would expect the earliest sources to be the most mythic and the latest sources to show increasing historical specificity.

The evidence matches the second prediction, not the first.

- **Paul** (50s CE): the earliest source. Jesus is a cosmic figure known through revelation and scripture. No birthplace, no ministry, no named contemporaries, no narrative of earthly life. The most mythic, least historical layer.

- **Mark** (*c.* 70 CE): the first narrative. A minimal biographical framework is introduced—Galilee, Jerusalem, crucifixion under Pilate—but much of the content is constructed from scriptural templates. No birth narrative, no resurrection appearances (the original ending at Mark 16:8), no genealogy.

- **Matthew and Luke** (*c.* 80–90 CE): birth narratives are added (mutually contradictory, constructed from proof-texts). Genealogies are supplied. Post-resurrection appearances are narrated. The historical framework expands significantly.

- **John** (*c.* 90–100 CE): a different chronology is introduced (three-year ministry vs. one year), new episodes are added (Lazarus, the Samaritan woman, the wedding at Cana), and extended theological discourses are placed in Jesus's mouth.
- **Later apocrypha** (second century and beyond): childhood miracles (Infancy Gospel of Thomas), extended dialogues with Pilate (Acts of Pilate), detailed accounts of the descent into hell (Gospel of Nicodemus), family details, and biographical elaboration continue to accumulate.

The trajectory is unmistakable: from cosmic and mythic to biographical and historically situated, from abstract to concrete, from silence about earthly details to proliferating specification. This is the signature of euhemerization—the process by which a mythic figure is progressively anchored in historical time and place—not of mythologization, which would produce the reverse trajectory.

The historicist response is that the later elaboration represents legendary accretion around a historical core, not euhemerization. But this response assumes the conclusion: it presupposes that the earliest layer (Paul) contains a historical figure who is simply not discussed in biographical terms, rather than a mythic figure who has not yet been historicized. The direction of the trajectory cannot distinguish between these interpretations *by itself*, but in combination with the evidence analyzed in previous sections—the celestial character of Paul's Christ, the scriptural construction of the Gospels, the silence of non-Christian sources—the euhemerization model provides a more coherent and parsimonious account.

## 9.2 Euhemerization as a Documented Process

Euhemerization—named after the Greek mythographer Euhemerus (*c.* 300 BCE), who argued that the gods were originally human kings deified after death—is a well-attested process in the ancient world. The reverse process—the historicization of mythic figures—is also documented, though less commonly discussed.

Romulus, the legendary founder of Rome, was originally a mythic figure (son of Mars, suckled by a she-wolf, ascended to heaven as the god Quirinus) who was progressively historicized into a "real" king with specific dates, political actions, and a detailed biography. No serious historian treats Romulus as historical, despite the extensive biographical tradition. The parallel with Jesus illustrates the principle: elaborate biographical detail does not require a historical person; it requires a mythic tradition with cultural motivation to anchor itself in history.

However, the Romulus parallel has a significant disanalogy that must be acknowledged: the historicization of Romulus took centuries, while the Jesus tradition produced a bio-

graphical narrative (Mark) within approximately forty years of the supposed events, and Paul's letters— which already presuppose established communities worshipping Christ—appear within twenty to twenty-five years. This is fast for euhemerization, and the speed of development is a genuine challenge for the mythicist model. The historicist argues that the rapid emergence of a biographical tradition is more easily explained by the existence of a historical person around whom the tradition formed.

Several considerations mitigate, though they do not eliminate, this challenge.

First, the relevant time-compression is narrower than it appears. Paul's letters (50s CE) do *not* show historicization: Paul's Jesus is cosmic, not biographical. The historicization occurs between Paul and Mark—a window of perhaps fifteen to twenty years. The question is whether a mythic figure can be placed in a specific historical setting within one generation. This is fast, but not unprecedented.

Second, the Cargo Cults of Melanesia, documented by anthropologists in the twentieth century, provide direct evidence that rapid historicization is possible. In several cases, mythic or divine figures were assigned specific names, biographical details, and historical contexts within a single generation, producing traditions that look, from the inside, like historical memory but are demonstrably mythic in origin [Lindstrom, 1993, Worsley, 1957]. The conditions that facilitated this—cultural upheaval caused by contact with a dominant foreign power, intense eschatological expectation, communities under existential stress—arguably obtained in first-century Roman Palestine.

Third, the specific conditions of the early Christian movement were unusually conducive to rapid historicization. The movement was geographically dispersed across the Mediterranean within two decades (Paul's letters attest this). It encountered diverse audiences who valued historical narrative. It operated within a scriptural tradition that provided ready-made biographical templates (the Elijah-Elisha cycle, the Suffering Servant, the Psalmic righteous sufferer). And it faced apologetic pressure: a movement claiming a cosmic Lord who had defeated death would face the question "when and where did this happen?" from every audience it addressed. The Gospel of Mark can be understood as the first systematic answer to that question—a biographical narrative assembled from scriptural templates to give the cosmic Christ a historical address.

Fourth, the relevant comparison is not with Romulus (where historicization occurred in a literate culture with stable institutions) but with new religious movements in periods of rapid social change. Joseph Smith produced a detailed historical narrative for the Book of Mormon within a few years. The Sabbatean movement reinterpreted Sabbatai Zevi's apostasy into a mythological framework within months. Religious movements under pressure can produce elaborate narrative constructions very quickly.

These considerations do not fully resolve the time-compression problem. The speed of the Paul-to-Mark transition remains a point where the historicist model has a structural advantage: a historical person provides an obvious catalyst for rapid narrative development that the mythicist model must explain through other mechanisms. But the mechanisms are available, and the speed is not so extreme as to make the mythicist model implausible—merely more demanding of explanation.

The mechanism by which historicization occurs is straightforward. A community that worships a mythic figure has practical reasons to anchor that figure in historical time and place: it makes the figure more relatable, more authoritative, and more resistant to charges of fabrication. As the movement grows and encounters audiences that value historical narrative (as Roman culture did), the pressure to historicize increases. The Gospel of Mark can be understood as the first major expression of this pressure within the Christian movement: the creation of a biographical narrative for a figure who had previously been known only through revelation and scripture. But whether the twenty-to-forty-year window is sufficient for this process—without a historical catalyst—remains an open question that the mythicist model has not fully resolved.

# 10 The Sociology of the Consensus

If the evidence for the historical Jesus is as weak as this paper contends, an explanation is required for the near-universal consensus in its favor. The explanation lies not in the evidence but in the institutional and sociological structure of the field.

## 10.1 Theological Origins of the Discipline

The academic study of the "historical Jesus" originated in and has been conducted primarily within institutions with theological commitments. The first and second "quests" for the historical Jesus (Schweitzer 1906; Käsemann 1954) were conducted almost entirely by Protestant theologians working within divinity schools and seminary faculties. The third quest, while broader in institutional base, remains heavily centered in departments of religious studies and theological faculties where Christianity is not merely an object of study but the institutional *raison d'être*.

This matters because the historicity of Jesus is not merely an academic question in these settings; it is a presupposition of the enterprise. A department of historical Jesus studies that concluded there was no historical Jesus would have undermined its own reason for existence. This is not a conspiracy; it is an ordinary institutional dynamic in which certain conclusions

are structurally discouraged by the conditions of employment, funding, and professional advancement.

Thompson [2005], a distinguished Old Testament scholar at the University of Copenhagen, reported that his questioning of the historicity of the patriarchs and of Jesus provoked professional hostility disproportionate to the evidential merits of his arguments. Brodie [2012], a Dominican priest and New Testament scholar, described being effectively silenced within his order after publishing his mythicist conclusions in *Beyond the Quest for the Historical Jesus*. These are not isolated anecdotes; they illustrate the professional costs of dissent on this particular question.

## 10.2 Paradigm Maintenance and Institutional Pressure

Kuhn [1962] described the process by which scientific paradigms are maintained: anomalies are accommodated through auxiliary hypotheses, fundamental assumptions become invisible because they are absorbed during training rather than independently evaluated, and challenges to the paradigm are treated as challenges to the competence or good faith of the challenger rather than as evidential contributions.

The historicity consensus exhibits all of these features. Anomalies—the silence of Paul on biographical details, the absence of non-Christian attestation, the scriptural construction of the narrative—are accommodated by auxiliary hypotheses ("Paul's letters are occasional correspondence," "Jesus was too obscure," "the authors used scripture to describe real events"). Each auxiliary hypothesis is individually possible, but their accumulation constitutes exactly the pattern of paradigm maintenance that Kuhn described: the core assumption is protected by an expanding shell of *ad hoc* defenses.

The treatment of mythicists exemplifies the sociological dynamics of paradigm protection. Ehrman [2012] dismisses mythicism as a position held by no "competent scholar," defining competence in terms so narrow as to exclude anyone who disagrees. He repeatedly invokes the consensus as evidence, a maneuver that would be recognized as circular in any other field. The rhetoric is not that of a scholar engaging with evidence; it is that of a paradigm defender policing the boundaries of acceptable opinion.

This is not unique to Ehrman. The professional response to Carrier [2014]—a peer-reviewed monograph published by an academic press, written by a scholar with a doctorate in ancient history from Columbia University—has been largely dismissal rather than engagement. The book has received few formal academic reviews relative to its significance. This is the sociological signature of a claim that the field does not wish to address on its merits.

## 10.3 Engagement with Anti-Mythicist Scholarship

Intellectual honesty requires acknowledging the most sophisticated historicist responses to mythicism rather than caricaturing them. Four bodies of work deserve specific notice.

Ehrman [2012] remains the standard broadly-accessible academic rebuttal. Its strengths are its clarity and its marshaling of the source-plurality and minimal-facts arguments. This paper engages its key moves in §3.4 (the *adelphos tou kyriou* passage), §4.2 (the independence of the supposed sources), and §8.6 (the crucifixion-as-scandal argument). Its reliance on consensus as evidence in its own right has been discussed in §2.1. Where Ehrman's specific arguments survive scrutiny—notably the cumulative structure of Paul's references to "the twelve" and "those who were apostles before me" (Gal 1:17, 1 Cor 15:5–7), and the evidentiary force of Paul's acknowledged meeting with Peter and James in Jerusalem (Gal 1–2, conducted twenty-odd years after any supposed crucifixion and constituting a chain of acquaintance at minimum two persons removed from Jesus)—we concede the force and engage the substance. Where the arguments reduce to consensus-claims, we note that reduction.

Casey [2014] offers the most combative historicist critique of mythicism. Casey argues that Aramaic sources underlie the Greek Gospels, that the tradition preserves genuine memories transmitted in Aramaic-speaking communities, and that mythicists lack the linguistic competence to evaluate the evidence. The Aramaic-source argument has real force: it suggests that at least some Gospel material passed through an Aramaic-speaking milieu, which is a non-trivial constraint on any mythic-origin scenario. It does not, however, establish historicity on its own: Aramaic transmission is consistent with an Aramaic-speaking sectarian community developing its theology through scriptural exegesis. Casey's *ad hominem* attacks on mythicist credentials do not address the substance of the arguments.

Meier [1991] (and its subsequent volumes) represents the most comprehensive historicist reconstruction to date. Meier's methodological caution is admirable, and his willingness to declare large portions of the tradition unrecoverable is more honest than many historicist treatments. Meier's project, however, presupposes historicity rather than establishing it: he asks "what can we know about the historical Jesus?" rather than "did a historical Jesus exist?" That framing is defensible within a research programme that has accepted historicity as a starting premise; it does not address the question this paper raises about whether the premise is warranted.

Allison [2010] and Allison [2021] are, in the judgement of this paper, the strongest sustained historicist case currently in print. Allison is as methodologically sceptical about the criteria of authenticity as any mythicist (§2.4) and has explicitly moved toward memory-theory as the post-criteria framework within which historicist reconstruction should pro-

ceed. Allison's claim is that the *gestalt* of the tradition—its recurring motifs, its stable narrative shape across otherwise-independent witnesses—is better explained by the memory of a historical figure than by purely literary construction. This paper grants that gestalt-level arguments are the most sophisticated form of the historicist case and that they cannot be dismissed by pointing to individual episodes' literary derivation. We contend, however, that the same gestalt features can be explained by a dense scriptural- and-revelatory generative process operating in a cohesive sectarian community, and that Allison's argument requires the additional assumption that memory rather than exegesis is the more parsimonious source of the gestalt—an assumption that requires independent defence, which is the argument of §8.

Finally, it is worth naming the Kuhnian dynamic that sustains consensus on unusually-embedded premises [Kuhn, 1962]: the premises least subject to critical re-examination are not those least well supported but those most deeply absorbed during disciplinary formation, because they are the premises on which both believers and sceptics within a given field have historically agreed. The historicity of Jesus has that status: it is the shared starting premise of confessional scholarship, secular scholarship, and even much critical scholarship since Schweitzer. Premises that hold that position are unusually resistant to scrutiny. This is not an indictment of any individual scholar's competence or good faith; it is an observation about how any discipline handles its most deeply embedded assumptions. It is not evidence against historicity. It is the reason this paper insists on re-examining the primary evidence directly rather than relying on the weight of consensus to settle the question.

# 11 A Constructive Alternative: The Mythicist Origin Scenario

A responsible challenge to the historicist consensus must do more than identify weaknesses in the evidence; it must offer a constructive alternative that explains the origin of Christianity without a historical founder. The following sketch draws on the work of Doherty [1999, 2009], Carrier [2014], and earlier scholars in the tradition, while noting points of genuine uncertainty.

**Stage 1: The celestial Christ (*c.* 30s–50s CE).** A small Jewish sectarian community, steeped in Second Temple scriptural exegesis, developed a soteriology centered on a celestial intermediary figure. This figure was assembled from existing Jewish theological raw materials: the Suffering Servant of Isaiah 52–53, the vindicated righteous one of Wisdom 2–5, the

Danielic Son of Man (Daniel 7:13–14), the Logos/Wisdom tradition developed by Philo and earlier Jewish thinkers, and angelomorphic figures such as those in 1 Enoch and the Dead Sea Scrolls. The community understood this figure—named *Iēsous* (Joshua/Jesus, meaning "Yahweh saves")—as a pre-existent divine being who descended into the domain of flesh, died as a vicarious sacrifice "in accordance with the scriptures," was raised by God, and was exalted to cosmic lordship.

The community's knowledge of this figure came through two channels: scriptural exegesis (reading the Hebrew Bible as encoding the Christ mystery) and visionary revelation (ecstatic experiences interpreted as encounters with the risen Lord). Paul's letters are the primary evidence for this stage: they describe exactly this kind of figure, known through exactly these channels.

**Stage 2: Community formation and diversification (*c.* 40s–60s CE).** The movement spread across the Mediterranean, establishing communities in major cities (Corinth, Thessalonica, Philippi, Rome). Different communities developed different emphases—some more apocalyptic, some more wisdom-oriented, some more Hellenized—but all shared the core soteriology of the dying and rising Christ. Leadership disputes emerged (Paul vs. the Jerusalem "pillars"), ritual practices diversified (the Lord's Supper, baptism, prophecy), and the tradition began generating "sayings of the Lord" through prophetic revelation attributed to the risen Christ. This accounts for the small number of "commands of the Lord" Paul cites (1 Corinthians 7:10, 9:14), as well as the wider body of sayings that would eventually be compiled in Q or its equivalent.

**Stage 3: Historicization in Mark (*c.* 70 CE).** The destruction of the Jerusalem Temple in 70 CE was a theological crisis for Judaism and for Jewish-Christian communities. In this context, the author of Mark composed the first narrative gospel: a biographical account of the Christ figure, set in recent Palestinian history, structured around a journey from Galilee to Jerusalem culminating in crucifixion under Pontius Pilate. Mark built his narrative from the available materials: the Elijah-Elisha cycle for the ministry, the Psalms and Isaiah for the passion, and the theological traditions of the community for the overall framework. Mark's Jesus *is* the celestial Christ of Paul, given a historical address.

The motivations for historicization were practical: a narrative set in identifiable times and places was more compelling to audiences accustomed to Greco-Roman biography; it answered the question "when and where did this happen?"; it provided a framework for organizing the scattered sayings and teachings attributed to the Lord; and it made the tradition more resistant to the charge that the Christ was merely a philosophical abstraction.

**Stage 4: Elaboration (*c.* 80–100 CE and beyond).** Matthew and Luke independently expanded Mark's narrative, adding birth narratives (from different scriptural templates), genealogies, resurrection appearances, and additional teaching material. John produced a theologically distinct narrative with a different chronology and new episodes. Subsequent centuries produced further elaboration: childhood miracles, detailed Pilate dialogues, harrowing-of-hell narratives, and the full apparatus of Christian hagiography.

**Assessment.** This scenario is *constructive*: it provides a coherent account of how Christianity could have originated and developed without a historical founder. It is *consistent* with all the evidence analyzed in this paper: Paul's celestial Christ, the scriptural construction of the Gospels, the silence of non-Christian sources, the mythological parallels, and the source trajectory from mythic to historical. It is *not proven*: alternative scenarios (including historicity) remain possible. But it demonstrates that the mythicist hypothesis is not merely a negation of historicism; it is a positive historical model with explanatory power.

The scenario's weakest points—the speed of the Paul-to-Mark transition (Section 9.2), the specificity of the 1 Corinthians 15 witness list (Section 3.2), and the two "commands of the Lord" (Section 3.3)—have been openly acknowledged throughout this paper. These remain genuine challenges. But they are challenges of detail, not of structure: the overall architecture of the mythicist scenario fits the evidence, and the individual difficulties admit possible (if not yet fully satisfying) explanations.

# 12 Conclusion

The evidence for the historical existence of Jesus of Nazareth has been examined across every available category: the Pauline epistles, the canonical Gospels, non-canonical Christian sources, non-Christian attestation, and the documentary traditions that should contain references but do not. The findings may be summarized as follows.

The Pauline corpus, the earliest stratum of Christian writing, primarily describes a celestial, revelatory figure known through scripture and visionary experience. The single passage most frequently cited as decisive for historicity—Galatians 1:19, "brother of the Lord"—is more ambiguous than the consensus acknowledges, particularly in light of the plural "brothers of the Lord" in 1 Corinthians 9:5. However, several Pauline passages pose genuine challenges for the mythicist model: Galatians 4:4 ("born of a woman, born under the law"), Romans 1:3 ("descended from David according to the flesh"), and the specificity of the witness list in 1 Corinthians 15:3–8. Mythicist readings of these passages are possible but require interpretive work that the historicist readings do not, and intellectual honesty requires acknowledging

this asymmetry.

The Gospel narratives are demonstrably constructed from Hebrew Bible templates. The passion narrative maps onto Psalm 22, Isaiah 53, Wisdom 2–5, and Zechariah point by point. The birth narratives are mutually contradictory and built from proof-texts. The ministry episodes recapitulate the Elijah-Elisha cycle. This templating does not by itself prove the non-historicity of a subject—historical persons can be described through scriptural grammars—but it does establish that the Gospels are not independent historical testimony. They testify to the theological constructions of late-first-century communities, not to witness memory of an event. The historicist evidential burden therefore cannot be carried by the Gospels; it must be carried by Paul and the non-Christian attestation, each of which is constrained and limited as analysed above.

The non-canonical Christian sources—Thomas, the Didache, 1 Clement, Barnabas—reinforce this finding. The earliest non-Pauline sources construct their Jesus from scripture and creed, not from biographical memory.

The non-Christian attestation is weaker than the consensus typically claims but not empty. The *Testimonium Flavianum* is partially or wholly interpolated. The James passage in Josephus is accepted by most textual scholars as substantially genuine and constitutes the strongest non-Pauline evidence for historicity, though its evidential value is limited. Tacitus almost certainly derives his information from Christian tradition. Collectively, the non-Christian sources confirm that by the late first and early second centuries the historicized narrative was in wide circulation—a datum that constrains both hypotheses.

The silence of contemporaneous sources—Philo, Justus of Tiberias, the Mishnaic tradition, Roman administrative records—constitutes disconfirming evidence whose qualitative weight favors the mythic-origin hypothesis. However, the individual silences vary in strength: some (Justus of Tiberias) are suggestive, while others (the Mishnah, a legal code rather than a chronicle) are weak. The cumulative argument from silence retains force but cannot be honestly quantified with the precision that a naive Bayesian calculation might suggest.

Every element of Paul's Christology and of the Gospel narrative has identifiable prior sources in pre-Christian Second Temple Jewish literature: the Danielic Son of Man, the Suffering Servant of Isaiah, the Wisdom-pattern of the persecuted-and-vindicated righteous one, angelomorphic mediator traditions, Philo's Logos, Hebrew Bible typology across the narrative arc, and Davidic messianic grammar. The Hellenistic literary environment supplied the ambient biographical conventions within which those Jewish materials were articulated, but the generative theological machinery is Jewish, not pagan. The earlier mythicist framing that located the primary source in pagan dying-and-rising mystery cults is the weaker form of the argument and is not the one this paper defends. The specific mode of death—Roman

crucifixion—poses a genuine question for the mythic-origin model, but is plausibly explained by Deuteronomy 21:23 as exploited in Galatians 3:13: a death specifically under scriptural curse is the mode of death required for a substitutionary-curse theology.

The source trajectory runs from mythic to historical—from Paul's cosmic Christ through Mark's minimal narrative to the elaborated biographies of Matthew, Luke, and John—which is consistent with euhemerization. However, the speed of this development (a biographical narrative within forty years) is fast for euhemerization and constitutes a genuine challenge that the mythicist model must address.

The scholarly consensus in favor of historicity is sustained partly by the institutional structure of the field—its theological origins, its paradigmatic assumptions, and the professional costs of dissent. This sociological observation does not make the consensus false, but it means the consensus cannot be invoked as independent evidence for historicity.

**Overall assessment.** This paper has argued that the evidence for the historical Jesus is substantially weaker than the consensus claims, and that the mythic-origin model provides a parsimonious account of much of the evidence—particularly the Pauline material, the scriptural construction of the Gospels, and the silence of contemporaneous sources.

It has not argued, and does not claim, that mythicism has been *proven* more probable than historicity. Several features of the evidence—the Pauline passages that admit historical readings (Galatians 4:4, Romans 1:3, 1 Corinthians 15:3–8), the specificity of crucifixion, the speed of the tradition's development, and the Josephan James passage—pose genuine difficulties for the mythicist model that have not been fully resolved.

The responsible conclusion is that the evidence does not establish the historicity of Jesus with the confidence the consensus claims. The mythicist hypothesis is a serious alternative that the evidence does not rule out. Responsible scholarship must acknowledge that the historicity question is legitimately disputed and that the mythicist model—while not proven—provides a coherent, evidence-based account of Christian origins that merits engagement on its merits rather than dismissal by appeal to authority.

To be explicit about what this paper has *not* argued: it has not argued that Jesus definitely did not exist. It has not argued that mythicism is proven. It has not argued that all historicist scholars are incompetent or acting in bad faith. It has argued that the evidence is insufficient to support the near-certainty the consensus projects, that the mythicist hypothesis is a serious alternative that survives scrutiny of its weaknesses, and that the scholarly consensus is sustained partly by institutional and methodological inertia rather than by evidential weight alone.

The historicity of Jesus is not established beyond reasonable historical doubt. The ques-

tion should be treated as genuinely open. And if the field cannot bring itself to treat it as open—if the mere posing of the question continues to be treated as a mark of incompetence rather than as a legitimate scholarly inquiry—then the field has a problem that no amount of consensus can resolve.

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